



Memory Bank

Institut Français de Presse (IFP)

Master's in Information and Communication Sciences

Supervised by Fabrice d'Almeida

2025/2026 M1 Global Journalism and Communication

Platformized Music Subcultures and the Algorithmic Formation of Community: A Social Network Analysis of Barber Beats on YouTube

Author: Barrier Arthur

Supervised by Jaercio Da Silva

Disclaimer

The author declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

In accordance with French research regulations, this study did not require formal approval from an institutional ethics committee. The research was conducted in compliance with ethical standards, including data minimisation, anonymisation of participants, and respect for privacy.

The data supporting the findings of this study are not publicly available due to confidentiality and ethical considerations, but may be available from the author upon reasonable request.

The Faculty does not intend to endorse or disapprove of the opinions expressed.

Abstract

This thesis investigates the formation and structure of the Barber Beats community on YouTube, a digital-native micro-genre of vaporwave whose listeners often attribute their discovery to the platform's recommendation algorithm. The study asks how platform affordances, metadata practices, and community-driven authenticity norms collectively produce a coherent musical subculture that remains almost entirely invisible within YouTube's formal social graph. Employing Social Network Analysis, three complementary network layers are reconstructed from 5,668 videos and approximately 300,000 tags across twelve channels—ten core Barber Beats producers and two methodological outliers (a different-genre channel and an AI-generated vaporwave channel). The co-commenting network reveals dense audience circulation organised around central artists, while the tag co-usage network demonstrates a decentralised convergence on shared metadata vocabularies. By contrast, the channel subscription and recommendation network shows near-total absence of formal institutional ties. Overall, the study argues that platformized cultural communities emerge through a continuous negotiation between algorithmic infrastructures and human meaning-making: the algorithm creates conditions of encounter, but the community creates conditions of belonging. This research contributes empirical documentation of an understudied digital music culture, a replicable multi-layer network methodology, and theoretical insights into cultural autonomy within highly platform-dependent environments.

Keywords:

Barber Beats; Vaporwave; YouTube; algorithmic curation; social network analysis; digital music subcultures; metadata; Covid-19 pandemic

Contents

I. Introduction	<i>p.6</i>
I.1. Research Problem and Entry Point	<i>p.8</i>
I.2. Core Argument and Hypotheses	<i>p.8</i>
I.3. Research Questions	<i>p.9</i>
I.4. Methodology, Scope and Structure	<i>p.10</i>
I.5. Structure of the Thesis	<i>p.11</i>
II. Background: From Vaporwave to Barber Beats	<i>p.12</i>
III. Conceptual Framework: Platformized Cultural Space	<i>p.18</i>
III.1. Platforms as Infrastructures of Visibility	<i>p.18</i>
III.1.a. Cultural consequences of platform affordances	<i>p.19</i>
III.1.b. The YouTube algorithm as community architect	<i>p.21</i>
III.2. Lefebvre and the Production of Digital Space	<i>p.23</i>
III.2.a. Online environments as lived social spaces	<i>p.24</i>
III.2.b. Bedroom production and remote creativity as spatial reconfiguration	<i>p.27</i>
III.3. The Attention Economy and Authenticity	<i>p.28</i>
III.3.a. Citton and Zuboff: attention as the scarce resource	<i>p.28</i>
III.3.b. Community-driven authenticity as resistance and gatekeeping	<i>p.30</i>
IV. Methodology	<i>p.32</i>
IV.1. Research Design and Theoretical Grounding	<i>p.33</i>
IV.2. Channel Selection and Sample Construction	<i>p.33</i>
IV.3. Data Extraction	<i>p.34</i>
IV.4. Co-commenting Network Construction	<i>p.34</i>
IV.5. Processing in R and Gephi	<i>p.37</i>
V. Results: Network Structures and Community Patterns	<i>p.38</i>
V.1. The Co-commenting Network: Mapping Shared Audiences	<i>p.38</i>

VI. Analysis: Mechanisms of Platformization in the Barber Beats Community	<i>p.38</i>
VI.1. Fragmentation and the Rise of Micro-Audiences	<i>p.42</i>
VI.2. Algorithmic Curation as Cultural Gatekeeper	<i>p.44</i>
VI.3. Authenticity, Gatekeeping, and the Treatment of 'Bad Fit' Actors	<i>p.46</i>
VI.4. Metadata, Titles, and Thumbnails as Identity Signals	<i>p.48</i>
VI.5. The Covid Interlude as Confirmation	<i>p.49</i>
VII. Discussion	<i>p.52</i>
VII.1. What Subcultures Teach Us About Platformized Cultural Production	<i>p.52</i>
VII.2. Implications for Cultural Autonomy and Platform Power	<i>p.54</i>
VII.3. Limitations of the Study	<i>p.56</i>
VIII. Conclusion	<i>p.58</i>
Bibliography / Citation Index	<i>p.60</i>
Appendix	<i>p.62</i>

I. Introduction

Social media shapes politics. An individual's opinion is not a fixed concept, it evolves according to its context and through experiences. In the age of information, we are exposed to significantly more experiences than before, although fewer of them are lived first-hand. The production rate of this information is such that it is impossible to quantify or digest it all. Social network agents are obligated to make choices regarding their information consumption, which would seem to bring the formation of their opinions back into their own hands. The first of these decisions is the network they will consume information from: this is a generational, contextual choice, influenced by socio-cultural factors and prone to constant change. A given online social network attracts certain communities that produce and consume their own information, largely different in its shape and content than information produced and consumed on other platforms. Quantitative studies in Social Sciences have and continue to explore quantifiable social networks and observed how a range of scholars interpret their shapes to explain or predict phenomenon. Focused predominantly on political opinion and its consequences and knowledge sharing, these studies tend to gravitate towards platforms suited for these activities. Twitter and its vocal users making for readily analyzable data, citation networks of scholarly articles and their epicurious optimism, biological networks for an interdisciplinary challenge.

Within this environment, the choice of platform is itself a structuring act. Each major digital platform attracts particular communities with particular information shapes, rhythms, and norms; the same individual inhabiting different platforms inhabits, in a meaningful sense, different social worlds. This thesis takes that observation seriously as a research premise. Rather than treating platform choice as a background condition, it treats it as an object of analysis — asking not only what communities do on platforms but how platforms actively participate in producing the communities that use them. The specific community examined here is one I know from inside, and one that makes the dynamics of platform-mediated community formation unusually visible.

I argue platform choice greatly impacts us, and since I am no exception I intend to dissect the network I know best: the Vaporwave and Barber Beat genre. Gaining popularity in 2020 with lockdown pushing people around the world to discover music differently, this genre is one of the first to owe most of its success to the YouTube algorithm. With colorful album artwork combining vintage and modern designs that became a staple of these releases, and

poetic titles surrounding them with mystery, intrigued YouTube users often comment how they randomly stumbled upon these videos Barber Beats is a micro-genre of electronic music, a late offshoot of the vaporwave tradition that emerged in the early 2010s from online communities experimenting with sampled and transformed sounds. It is, in almost every meaningful sense, a digital-native cultural form: composed in domestic spaces using digital audio workstations, distributed through streaming platforms and personal websites, consumed through algorithmic recommendation rather than radio or retail, and organized around communities of practice that exist almost entirely in comment sections, Discord servers, and Bandcamp pages. The genre has no physical home, no headquarters, no governing body, and no official canon. It is held together by shared aesthetic sensibilities, informal norms, and the recommendation logic of the platform on which the majority of its audience first encounters it.

The comment sections beneath Barber Beats videos on YouTube contain a recurring observation, expressed in countless variations but always carrying the same recognition: 'the algorithm strikes again.' Listeners describe stumbling upon the music unexpectedly, through autoplay sequences or sidebar recommendations, as though the platform had identified something about their taste that they had not fully articulated to themselves. This phenomenon is widely noted within the community, accepted as part of the genre's mythology, and rarely examined further. This thesis takes it as its point of departure. The claim that the algorithm 'strikes again' is not merely a comment on discovery; it is an implicit theory of community formation. It proposes that the network of artists and listeners constituting the Barber Beats community did not assemble itself through deliberate coordination but was, in significant part, organized by the recommendation infrastructure of the platform on which it lives. Mapping, measuring, and interpreting that structure is the empirical ambition of this thesis.

The broader context that gives this project its urgency is the Covid-19 pandemic. Surging to a wide audience in 2020, during the first wave of global lockdowns, Barber Beats became briefly visible to a much larger population than it had previously reached. Social isolation, abundant domestic time, radically increased engagement with digital media: the conditions of the pandemic were something close to ideal for this micro genre. It reproduced, at societal scale, precisely the conditions of domestic digital creativity and platform-dependent discovery through which the community had been quietly forming for a decade. Alexandre notes: "the crisis has accelerated a paradigm shift: the cultural sector has gradually moved from a logic of scarcity [...] to a logic of abundance" (Alexandre et al 2022, 1). Notably, he then states that the crisis accelerated a paradigm shift in which the cultural sector moved from a

logic of scarcity to one of abundance, and how lockdowns fueled the substitution of physical cultural consumption by digitalized alternatives. For Barber Beats, this substitution was not a difficult adjustment but a confirmation. The genre had always operated in the digital space that the pandemic made suddenly central to everyone's life.

This historical coincidence frames the premise under which this thesis was developed: media after the crisis, return to normality. That phrase carries a double meaning in the context examined here. The crisis, here the pandemic and its cultural consequences, was for the Barber Beats community a period of anomalous expansion rather than disruption. At the same time, the digital space to which much of our activity moved was already the 'normal' realm of the genre.

I.2. Core Argument and Hypotheses

The central argument of this thesis is that the Barber Beats community on YouTube is not an accidental aggregation of similar tastes. It is a structured product of platform affordances, collective metadata practices, and community-driven authenticity mechanisms. Its structure is simultaneously invisible at the formal platform level and coherent at the informal level. Interestingly, these two features are not in tension. Instead, the invisibility is a consequence of the coherence, the result of a community that has organized itself through channels the platform was not designed to make legible.

From this central argument, three hypotheses follow. The first is that the community's structural shape is substantially determined by algorithmic recommendation: the network reflects patterns generated both by the platform's recommendation logic and by deliberate listener and artist choice. The second hypothesis is that shared metadata practices (the convergence on a common tag vocabulary, visual grammar, and titling style) represent a form of collective adaptation to platform infrastructure, through which a decentralized community of producers has informally coordinated its own discoverability without any central authority prescribing that coordination. Thirdly, the community enforces authenticity criteria that operate independently of and as a corrective force to algorithmic classification. I posit that listeners distinguish between content that is formally compatible with the genre and content that is culturally legitimate within it, and use both filters to determine what Barber Beats truly represents.

Underlying all three hypotheses is a broader claim about the relationship between platform logics and cultural community formation. Kaiser and Rauchfleisch, in their study of YouTube's role in the circulation of alternative political content, identified the platform's channel recommendation as a mechanism that connects otherwise isolated communities, arguing that diverse channels that might remain separated without the algorithm's intervention are brought into contact through it (Kaiser et al, 2018). This thesis extends that observation into the domain of musical subculture, proposing that the same dynamic produces not only political but cultural communities — and that, in the case of Barber Beats, the community assembled through algorithmic recommendation has developed precisely the internal norms, aesthetic codes, and gatekeeping practices necessary to sustain itself as a coherent cultural formation. The algorithm creates the conditions of encounter; the community creates the conditions of belonging.

I.3. Research Questions

The empirical and theoretical ambitions of this thesis converge on four research questions, each operating at a different level of abstraction and addressed with a different combination of methods.

The first question is a structural one: what is the shape of the Barber Beats community on YouTube, and what mechanisms explain that shape? This question is addressed through Social Network Analysis of three distinct data layers: a co-commenting network capturing audience overlap across channels, a tag co-usage network capturing collective metadata practices, and a channel subscription and recommendation network capturing direct institutional relationships between creators.

The second question concerns platform affordances: how do the technical features of YouTube function as de facto gatekeepers for this micro-genre community? This question is addressed through the conceptual framework developed in Chapter II, drawing on Helmond's theory of platformization (Helmond 2015, 1), the notion of affordances as the possibilities that technological systems enable and constrain, and Seaver's characterization of recommendation algorithms as 'captivating technologies' whose operation cannot be separated from the cultural contexts in which they are embedded (Seaver 2015, 35).

The third question pertains the relationship between algorithmic and human curation: to what extent do community-driven authenticity norms interact with, resist, or compensate for algorithmic classification? This question motivates the inclusion of two outlier channels in the empirical sample to reveal how the community responds to actors who are algorithmically similar but culturally divergent.

The fourth question reaches beyond the specific case: what does the structure of this small-scale digital subculture reveal about broader dynamics of platformized cultural production, particularly in the context of the crisis and normality dialectic that the pandemic made newly urgent? This question is addressed primarily in the closing discussion chapter, where the findings of the network analysis are interpreted in relation to the wider literature on digital music economies, platform governance, and the cultural consequences of datafication.

I.4. Methodology, Scope and Structure

This thesis adopts Social Network Analysis as its primary methodological framework. SNA treats social organization not as a set of attributes possessed by individual actors but as a set of relationships between them, making it possible to operationalize abstract concepts such as community, centrality, and influence through measurable network properties. Nodes and edges, edge weights, clustering coefficients, and centrality metrics provide empirical indicators of community structure that remain largely invisible through qualitative observation alone. In the context of a geographically dispersed, semi-anonymous digital community, this is a significant and necessary methodological advantage.

The empirical sample consists of twelve YouTube channels. Ten are core Barber Beats producers selected to represent a range of positions within the community — varying in audience size, production style, distribution practices, and degree of platform engagement. Two are outliers included as methodological stress tests: one channel producing music in a different genre (Drum and Bass/UKG) to assess the strength of genre boundaries in constraining audience overlap, and one channel generating content through artificial intelligence to assess how a community founded on human creative labor responds to a producer that replicates genre aesthetics while bypassing the practices those aesthetics are understood to encode. Since no comprehensive public directory of artists exists due to the semi-anonymous nature of the Barber Beats scene, channel identification required manual research and retrieval.

Data was extracted using YouTube Data Tools, developed by Bernhard Rieder, and processed in R and Gephi. The extraction yielded an initial dataset of 5,668 videos and approximately 300,000 associated tags, further refined as detailed in chapter 4. The ForceAtlas2 layout algorithm in Gephi was used to visualize and interpret the resulting network structures (Jacomy et al 2014).

I.5. Structure of the Thesis

The thesis proceeds in eight chapters, organized to move from historical and theoretical grounding, through empirical analysis, to broader interpretive reflection.

Chapter II provides the historical and contextual grounding for the object of study. It traces the material history of the genre, establishes the aesthetic and political identity of vaporwave as the tradition from which Barber Beats descended, and narrates the identity crisis of 2019. This history is an analytical imperative because the community's current structure cannot be understood without first unveiling the founding conditions from which it emerged, the values it has chosen to maintain, and the pressures that have tested and reshaped it.

Chapter III develops the conceptual framework in three parts. The first examines platforms as infrastructures of visibility, the second applies Henri Lefebvre's theory of the production of space to digital environments, and the third examines the attention economy through the work of Citton and Hracs and Webster.

Chapter IV details the methodology. It explains the research design and its theoretical grounding, describes the channel selection process and the criteria used to identify the sample, and gives a granular account of the data extraction, filtering, and processing steps.

Chapter V presents the results of the network analysis in three layers. The co-commenting network identifies the patterns of audience circulation across channels, the tag co-usage network captures the collective metadata practices through which creators manage their discoverability, and the channel subscription and recommendation network presents and interprets the near-null result.

Chapter VI provides the analysis of the network observations, organized around five mechanisms through which platformization shapes the Barber Beats community.

Chapter VII discussion drawing together the empirical findings, broader literature on platformized cultural production, and the results of this research to situate the thesis in a broader context. The limitations of the study are also acknowledged in this part, along with the questions they leave open.

III. Background: From Vaporwave to Barber Beats

I refer to musical subcultures as a set of artists, labels, listeners and practices that share a common interest for a musical genre that isn't available anywhere else but digitally (though that definition is challenged by monetization practices). I insist on their roles as subcultures due to the peculiar customs and identity constructed from what is initially just a variation in music structure. If we will later explore the means of this identity affirmation, the fact remains that digital native musical subcultures are plural and constantly expanding. Thus, it is imperative to determine a perimeter within which to observe the community's interaction in a relatively sterile environment without undermining internal validity. To do so, I will focus on a set amount of artists, all majoritarily producing within the same subculture: Vaporwave. As a disclaimer, this chapter draws primarily from the documentary *Nobody Here* (2026) directed by Christian Britten; I highly recommend its one of a kind in depth coverage of Vaporwave, though it regrettably one brushes over Barber Beats.

Vaporwave is part of the first generation of digital born microgenres. Though it stemmed in the early 2010's with specific actors contributing to its affirmation as its own cultural component, roots are evidently present in times much older. The act of repurposing sounds and combining them into new ones has existed for as long as the technology has permitted the general public to do it. Retracing the music industry's evolution is useful in that regard. It all begins with gramophones, using the vibration from a needle on a cylinder to store physical carvings of sounds, then playing them back as a similar needle attached to a membrane was ran along the carvings. Each cylinder requiring manual recording of the sound, that technology was eventually replaced with vinyl disks, as their flat format allowed for mass production by press.

The next music hardware was born out of a different problem: only a single 'take', as in musical performance, could be recorded simultaneously on discs, and cassette tapes fixed that problem by allowing the production of multiple superposed bands, facilitating the edit and allowing for much more complexity. Those cassette recorders mark the real starting point of Vaporwave, as the malleable tapes meant anyone could duplicate, change, and mix sounds over a cassette. This DIY era, further popularized by the boom of the 'walkman' — a portable cassette player made possible by removing the weight demanding recording functionalities — put the music industry at a disadvantageous position. Indeed, the 'homebrews' manufactured

by enthusiasts took control of the market out the major label's hands. If lighter and more compact music CDs brought them back control on copyrights later on, the idea that anyone could make their own collection of sounds stuck around. The advent of the internet exacerbated this practice by giving a platform to pioneers. Moreover, digital music catalogs rounded up all the tools necessary for elaborate creation. Sure enough, the combination of these circumstances led to the birth of vaporwave somewhere between 2011 and 2012.

This genre was first defined by its nostalgic feeling. Pieces emulated the late 80's and 90's feeling, as many producers sampled tv commercials, computer and video game sounds from that era. Atop these snippets from the past, an aether like filter and slowed down tempo became the central gimmick that makes vaporwave tracks easily recognizable. Another central element is the concept of liminal spaces: many vaporwave artworks depict shopping malls, airport lounges and metro stations completely empty of human presence. Bringing into question familiar spaces in new contexts, emulating the feeling of introspective voyages through known elements: those define the genre and allowed for a distinct aesthetic to become its focal point. A last debatable topic recurrent in vaporwave projects is a critique, or at least an acknowledgement, of consumerist practices, mass production and excessive advertisement. If it is only addressed satirically through glitched television advertisement audios, colorful plastic toys and fake branding styles on album covers, the anti-capitalist nature of the genre is not clear. Regardless of its use as another tool of nostalgia for the last decades of the 21st century or as cynicism about the current world, the presence of these elements also defined the early stages of Vaporwave.

After a first experimental period, where artists were primarily motivated to hone their own crafts and gradually reached out to form the initial web of the community, its structure grew to form virtual live events with hundreds of listeners tuning in periodically to streams on sketchy websites. From 2015 onwards, vaporwave knew multiple surges in popularity due to specific tracks gaining attention like when the album *Florral Shoppe* by Macintosh Plus went viral after music critique and youtuber Anthony Fantano reviewed it. Music magazines also started featuring vaporwave artists, and famous music critiques reviews flourished albums. This new attention also grew the controversy around the genre: reusing sounds meant the releases were never entirely original, and vaporwave producers were perceived as lazy and undeserving of the attention and revenue they bolstered. This pressure on the community culminated when a particularly popular vaporwave label, Dream Catalog, was featured on *Rolling Stone* (*Rolling Stone* 2015). Far from rejoicing, the label's owners quickly took it down

after that, scared that copyright infringement lawsuits would incur if the original audio owners discovered their works were being used without their knowledge.

Marking a turn for the genre, especially as the new label acting as Dream Catalog's legacy issued shortly after an album titled 'Vaporwave is dead', the heavy sampling was toned down for the years to come. Instead the focus on the electronic synthesizer waves and affirmation of the musical components of the genre led to pieces being increasingly unique to their producers. There, the combination of the online anonymity and wild creativity fostered by the community paired with the increasing organizational structure brought by independent labels led to a new form of consumption: cassette tapes. This first physical proof of vaporwave was easily integrated in its culture for its symbolism of a past era the genre was already drawing heavily upon. Furthermore, it cemented vaporwave as something bigger than purely musical — the artwork on the cassettes, and later on the vinyls and even wax rolls on which the music was distributed resonated with the rejection of and from mainstream streaming platforms.

Ironically, the genre born from the disgust of the music industry's excessive consumerism had just fallen into the same trap. Indeed, tapes were only the catalysts: soon in person meetings called 'tape swaps' were organized, where vaporwave enthusiasts could meet their peers, some artists, and exchange cassettes with one another. Although very localized and very majoritarily exclusive to the United States, those events made vaporwave producers realize there was a demand for more direct connection. With the success of an event at an exhibition in Philadelphia where pieces visually adjacent to the movement inspired the venue to host a vaporwave only dj set night, dreams of proper festivals emerged. Surely enough, in 2019 Electronica came round and confirmed the direction the genre had taken. With many of the core vaporwave artists performing, many showing their faces for the first time, the event was a bittersweet success. On one hand, it was a culmination of everything the community had been building up to for almost a decade, and a prime example of how influential internet culture can have over one's life trajectory. On the other hand, for the vaporwave movement this new era of live shows broke the founding precepts of digital anonymity. Worse even, the energy of live crowd led producers to adapt their style to a faster pace — dancey rhythm, with more vocals and improvisation instead of the usual filtered sounds.

I mark the first Electronica festival as the identity crisis that split up vaporwave. From there, I identify three main branches carrying out the features of the genre in different directions. The first is future funk: as the name implies, this subgenre builds on the groove of

funk to calibrate vaporwave for concerts. While retaining the visual identity of the neon sunsets and flashy retro futuristic elements, it relies on the dual identity of digital distribution and live events to continue the Electronica's legacy. The second subgenre is slushwave. Although born slightly before 2019, it grew in the opposite direction of future funk and hence welcomed the part of the initial community that was uncomfortable with the changing musical arrangement. In an interesting contrast, slushwave relies on even slower tempos than vaporwave, with extended tracks and more layers of sound distortion. Acting as a fundamentalist and minimalist version of the previous genre, it tries to extract its essence by retaining only the core lethargic nostalgia through carefully selected sounds. At last, the third subgenre that emerged from vaporwave's identity crisis is Barber Beats. In a nutshell, Barber Beats is a desire to return to what vaporwave meant at the beginning, when artists put together 'new artistic sentiments created from ones that already exist' (direct quote from Barber Beat's artist Silph Skyline's Bandcamp biography). Anyone could loop a sample from a song they listened to as a child and release a collection of these online.

Barber beats are digital by nature, since the birth of this type of music distribution can only exist in the periphery of institutionalized music consumption practices. Artists rely on a thin line of semi-visibility to grow their community. They need to keep enough distance from mainstream and label's gazes to avoid lawsuits and barriers to music distribution. To do so, they refrain from using their real identities, from collecting revenue from streams, and from appearing in live events. Instead, they will create ingenious aliases and immersive artist styles, encourage their listeners to support them financially through poster and cassette purchases, and some even make appearances in rare digital events. In essence, most barber beats artists still actively pursue the growth of their communities, yet do so in the confined freedom their digital existence allows for. This veil of mystery greatly hinders the scope of this analysis, as each case nests in a different spot of this virtual game of hide and seek.

The art of Barber beats derives from Vaporwave. It stems from that desire of limpid audio experiences but reaches into the most diverse genres to source its sounds. Strings from Muzak (a genre of the 1980 in which composers of orchestras would create an easy listening ambient from arrangements of several dozen orchestra instruments, often used in elevators and lounges). Drum breaks from hip hop and breakcore (themselves derived from blues and funk). Horns from all kinds of traditional music (mainly Italian, American and Japanese composers from the first half of the 20th century, although the sensibility and nationality of each barber beats producer greatly influence their composition choices). Various instruments also come

into play, and producers often center a given album on a set of inspirations (instrument, compositions from an author, tempo, sonority) to fully explore everything their samples have to offer. On top of this sampling layer, an understated amount of transformation truly makes those heteroclit sounds vaporwave. Artists must then assemble the pieces, very often creating music (bass lines, drum patterns) to better bring elements together. Many sound altering modules, frequency and soundwave treatments are then laid atop the piece to shape it into vaporwave, and constitute of the center of the artist's work: deep knowledge of the musical world, of the arrangements of wildly different genres.

III. Conceptual Framework: Platformized Cultural Space

III.1. Platforms as Infrastructures of Visibility

Digital platforms are often discussed as neutral channels through which cultural content circulates. Such a perspective, however, obscures the extent to which platforms actively shape the conditions of cultural production, distribution, and reception. Rather than functioning as passive intermediaries, platforms operate as infrastructures of visibility: they determine what content can be discovered, under which conditions it becomes visible, and how users encounter it. For creators whose existence depends almost entirely on digital circulation, such as Barber Beats producers on YouTube, these infrastructural conditions are not secondary considerations but fundamental constraints that shape artistic practice itself.

The concept of platformization provides a useful starting point for understanding this phenomenon. Helmond describes platformization as the process through which platforms extend their technical and economic logic across digital environments, arguing that it entails “the extension of social media platforms into the rest of the web and their drive to make external web data platform ready” (Helmond 2015, 1). Under this logic, visibility becomes increasingly dependent on compatibility with platform infrastructures. Cultural producers are therefore required not only to create content but also to package it in ways that can be recognized, categorized, and circulated by platform systems.

III.1.a. Cultural consequences of platform affordances

The notion of affordances is particularly useful for explaining how platforms influence cultural production. Affordances can be understood as the possibilities for action that technological systems enable, encourage, or constrain. Although users retain agency, their choices are shaped by the architecture within which they operate. On YouTube, recommendation systems, thumbnail displays, search indexing, metadata structures, and watch-time optimization mechanisms collectively create a set of incentives that guide both creators and audiences.

These technical features are especially significant in the case of digital music subcultures. Unlike artists supported by major labels or established promotional infrastructures, Barber Beats producers depend almost entirely on platform-mediated discovery. Their ability to attract listeners is therefore closely tied to how effectively their work aligns with the platform's visibility mechanisms. The production of music becomes inseparable from the production of discoverability.

This dynamic extends beyond simple questions of searchability. Hracs and Webster argue that curation has become central to platform value creation, defining it as the 'strategic selection, presentation and arrangement of information, goods, services, and people' (Hracs et al 2021, 241). Visibility on digital platforms is thus not determined solely by the quality of a musical work but also by how effectively it is curated through metadata, visual presentation, and audience engagement. In this sense, creators participate in a continuous process of self-curation designed to improve their position within platform infrastructures.

The visual identity of Barber Beats illustrates this process particularly well. Album covers frequently combine nostalgic imagery, neon colors, luxury consumer aesthetics, deserted urban environments, and retro graphic design. Similarly, titles often adopt poetic, cryptic, or emotionally evocative language rather than straightforward descriptions of musical content. While these choices undoubtedly carry aesthetic meaning, they also perform an infrastructural function. They help videos attract attention within crowded recommendation feeds and establish recognizable genre markers that facilitate both algorithmic classification and human recognition.

Tag usage operates according to a similar logic. Producers strategically employ tags associated with vaporwave, electronic music, nostalgia, ambient music, and related genres in order to increase the likelihood that their content will be indexed alongside similar works. Metadata therefore becomes more than a descriptive tool; it becomes a mechanism through which artists negotiate visibility within platform systems.

As a result, the basis of competition among creators shifts. Competition increasingly depends not merely on content itself but on "the engineering of compelling experiences that harness the unique and interconnected affordances of platformisation" observe Hracs and Webster (Hracs et al 2021, 240). For Barber Beats artists, success is consequently linked not only to musical composition but also to the effective orchestration of visual aesthetics,

metadata practices, release strategies, and audience engagement. The production of culture and the production of visibility become inseparable activities.

Yet this dependence on visibility introduces a significant paradox. Barber Beats emerged from communities strongly influenced by sampling practices, anonymity, and a degree of distance from mainstream music institutions. Excessive visibility can therefore represent a threat rather than an unqualified benefit. Greater exposure increases the likelihood of copyright scrutiny, commercial appropriation, and the dilution of subcultural identity. Artists must consequently navigate what may be described as a regime of semi-visibility: they need to be sufficiently visible to sustain audience growth while remaining sufficiently obscure to preserve the conditions that allow the genre to exist. Visibility is therefore pursued selectively rather than maximized indiscriminately.

III.1.b. The YouTube algorithm as community architect

If platform affordances structure the possibilities of visibility, recommendation algorithms determine how that visibility is distributed. The YouTube recommendation system occupies a particularly important position in this regard because it functions as the primary mechanism through which users encounter unfamiliar content. Many listeners discover Barber Beats not through deliberate searches but through automated recommendations appearing after adjacent videos. The recurring comment that 'the algorithm strikes again' reflects an awareness among users that their participation in the community is often mediated by recommendation systems rather than intentional exploration.

To understand this process, it is necessary to move beyond the idea of algorithms as purely technical tools. Recommender systems should be viewed as “captivating technologies”, whose operation cannot be separated from the cultural contexts in which they are embedded, argues Seaver (Seaver 2015, 35). Algorithms do not merely sort content according to objective criteria; they actively shape patterns of attention, interaction, and discovery: their influence is cultural as much as computational.

This perspective is especially relevant when examining the emergence of digital music communities. Rather than treating communities as pre-existing groups that happen to coincidentally use YouTube, it becomes possible to view the platform itself as a participant in their formation. Recommendation systems connect listeners to artists, artists to other artists,

and clusters of content to adjacent clusters. Through countless individual acts of recommendation, a broader community gradually acquires coherence.

This dynamic is increasingly pointed to by research on music platforms. Vizcaíno-Verdú for example, observes that algorithms are becoming central actors in guiding musical interests, shaping how users discover, consume, create, and share music-related content (Vizcaíno-Verdú et al 2023, 161). Musical preferences are therefore not formed independently of platform infrastructures but emerge through ongoing interaction with them. The visibility granted by recommendation systems directly influences which genres flourish, which artists gain audiences, and which cultural practices become sustainable.

“Algorithms and social mechanisms within streaming media may thus work in tandem to transform micro-events into macro-events” notes Maasø (Maasø 2016, 167). The cumulative effects of these processes can be substantial. Individual recommendations, comments, subscriptions, and shares may appear insignificant in isolation, yet their aggregation can generate large-scale patterns of attention. Small communities can therefore expand rapidly when algorithmic circulation aligns with social engagement.

In the case of Barber Beats, this mechanism is particularly important because the genre lacks many of the institutional structures traditionally associated with musical success. Major labels, radio promotion, physical distribution networks, and professional marketing campaigns play only a limited role. Instead, community growth depends largely on the interaction between audience behavior and platform recommendation systems. The algorithm effectively assumes functions traditionally associated with cultural intermediaries: it identifies promising content, introduces audiences to unfamiliar creators, and shapes pathways of discovery.

This does not imply that the algorithm acts alone, resonating with Seaver’s core argument which emphasizes algorithmic systems as fundamentally sociotechnical, involving both human and non-human actors (Seaver 2015, vii). Recommendation systems respond to user behavior, while users adapt their behavior to recommendation systems. Artists modify titles, thumbnails, and metadata in anticipation of algorithmic evaluation, while audiences learn to interpret these signals as indicators of genre membership. Community formation therefore emerges from the interaction of platform infrastructures and human practices rather than from either element independently.

Consequently, the Barber Beats network should not be understood as the product of deliberate coordination among artists alone. Its structure is shaped by an invisible yet powerful

architecture of recommendations, classifications, and visibility mechanisms that operate continuously in the background of platform activity. The YouTube algorithm functions not merely as a distributor of content but as a community architect, helping organize the social and cultural relationships that make the genre possible.

III.2. Lefebvre and the Production of Digital Space

If platforms determine visibility, they also provide the environments within which cultural communities emerge and interact. Previously, I argued that YouTube functions as an infrastructure governing discovery and circulation. Yet visibility alone cannot explain why dispersed individuals come to experience themselves as part of a coherent cultural community. To understand that process, it is necessary to move beyond the study of platforms as technical systems and instead examine them as social spaces.

Henri Lefebvre's theory of the production of space provides a useful framework for this task. Rejecting the notion that space exists as a neutral container in which social activity merely takes place, Lefebvre argues that space itself is socially produced. Every society creates the spatial arrangements required for its reproduction, embedding within them its values, hierarchies, rhythms, and structures of power. Space is therefore not passive; it is an active component of social life.

Although Lefebvre developed his theory long before the emergence of contemporary digital platforms, his insights remain remarkably relevant. The rise of social media, streaming services, online forums, and digital communication networks has generated new environments through which social relations are organized. If these spaces lack physical walls or geographical coordinates, they nevertheless structure interactions, shape experiences, and produce forms of belonging no less real than those found in traditional physical settings.

This perspective became particularly significant during the Covid-19 pandemic. As lockdown measures isolated populations and restricted movement, everyday life migrated into digital environments at an unprecedented scale. Activities once rooted in physical proximity — socializing, studying, cultural participation, entertainment, and even work — became increasingly dependent on networked technologies. The internet ceased to be merely one domain among others and instead became the dominant space through which daily rhythms

unfolded. In Lefebvre's terms, society responded to altered conditions by producing a new spatial arrangement capable of sustaining social life under unprecedented constraints.

Besides, these newly central digital spaces reproduced many of the inequalities already present in society. Access to virtual participation depended on technological infrastructure, economic resources, and digital literacy. The pandemic therefore revealed a profound spatial divide: while some populations could continue their activities through online platforms, others were effectively excluded from participation. The production of digital space was consequently inseparable from questions of power and access, acting as a reminder that virtual environments are no more neutral than physical ones.

III.2.a. Online environments as lived social spaces

Lefebvre famously distinguishes between different dimensions of space, notably perceived space, conceived space, and lived space. While platform designers may conceive digital environments through interfaces, algorithms, and technical architectures, users inhabit these spaces through everyday practices and experiences. It is this lived dimension that is particularly relevant for understanding digital music subcultures.

For Barber Beats listeners and producers, community does not emerge from physical proximity. Most participants will never meet one another, attend the same venues, or inhabit the same cities. Instead, social interaction unfolds through YouTube comment sections, Bandcamp pages, Discord servers, Reddit discussions, and other digital environments. These spaces serve functions traditionally associated with physical cultural scenes: they facilitate discovery, discussion, identity formation, and collective memory. All those being elements defining a category of social spaces known as third spaces, whose physical counterparts have significantly shrunk in the last decade.

Research on contemporary music cultures increasingly highlights this expansion of cultural participation beyond physical locations. Danielsen and Kjus observe that festivals and music events now extend far beyond their geographical and temporal boundaries through online activity, arguing that contemporary mediated events increasingly stretch “into a virtual realm” (Danielsen et al 2019, 717). Their observation is equally applicable to digital-native genres such as Barber Beats. Here, the virtual realm is not an extension of an existing physical community but rather its primary site of existence.

The importance of these spaces can be understood through the notion of lived space. For Lefebvre, lived space refers to the symbolic, emotional, and experiential dimension of spatial life. It is the space of imagination, attachment, and meaning-making. Digital environments clearly fulfill these functions. A YouTube comment section may appear technologically simple, yet it serves as a location where listeners share interpretations, express nostalgia, discuss influences, and establish communal norms. The emotional significance attached to these interactions demonstrates that digital spaces are experienced as genuinely social spaces rather than merely technical tools.

This dynamic became especially visible during periods of social isolation. As physical gathering became impossible, digital platforms increasingly functioned as lifelines connecting individuals to broader communities. Social relations were filtered through screens, interfaces, and platform architectures, yet they remained socially meaningful. The lived space of participants was transformed but not diminished. Rather, it was reconstituted through digital symbols, images, and interactions that shaped emotions and social relationships just as powerfully as physical encounters.

Danielsen and Kjøs report that events increasingly function as frameworks that help audiences navigate an overwhelming abundance of available media (Danielsen et al 2019, 717). Indeed, online environments do not simply host communities; they actively organize attention. In a similar way, Barber Beats communities provide orientation within YouTube's vast informational landscape. Community spaces operate as filters, helping listeners identify meaningful content, establish shared references, and develop collective understandings of the genre. The production of space therefore simultaneously becomes a production of cultural meaning, altering in turn the space they occupy.

Anonymity further reinforces the spatial distinctiveness of these environments. Many Barber Beats artists operate under pseudonyms, avoid public appearances, and cultivate enigmatic personas. This anonymity is often discussed as an aesthetic preference or a legal obligation, but it may also be understood as a spatial strategy. By obscuring connections to physical identities and locations, artists reinforce the autonomy of the digital environments in which they operate. Membership becomes defined less by geographical location than by participation in a shared symbolic universe.

The significance of this distinction becomes evident when considering moments in which digital and physical spaces intersect. The Electronica 2019 festival represented precisely

such a rupture. For many artists and listeners, the festival offered an opportunity to translate a fundamentally digital community into a physical gathering. Yet the ambivalent reactions it provoked reveal how deeply the community's identity had become attached to its digital spatiality. The controversy surrounding public appearances and live performances was not merely aesthetic; it reflected uncertainty about what would happen when a community produced in digital space was suddenly relocated into physical space.

III.2.b. Bedroom production and remote creativity as spatial reconfiguration

The production of digital space is not limited to audience interaction. It also transforms the spaces in which cultural production occurs. One of the defining characteristics of Barber Beats is that it emerged from conditions of decentralized and predominantly domestic creativity. Artists typically compose, edit, distribute, and promote their work from private spaces rather than professional studios.

This tendency predated the pandemic but became increasingly normalized during and after it. Covid-19 effectively transformed much of society into a large-scale version of what digital-native musicians had long experienced. Homes became offices, classrooms, cinemas, concert halls, and creative studios simultaneously. The boundaries separating domestic life from cultural production weakened dramatically.

Empirical research confirms this shift. The reorganization of everyday life during lockdown significantly increased engagement with digital cultural goods and services, note Jonchery and Lombardo (Jonchery et al 2020, 1). They further observe that younger generations were particularly active in developing amateur creative practices during this period (id). The domestic sphere consequently evolved from a space primarily associated with consumption into a site of production, experimentation, and participation.

For Barber Beats artists, this transformation was not exceptional but foundational. The genre emerged from a context in which digital audio workstations, online archives, and distribution platforms enabled individuals to produce music independently of traditional institutions. This point is precisely what reveals the flagrant gap between Vaporwave inherited culture and societal norms prior to lockdown. Barber Beats could only emerge in that context as that unprecedented period drew the bridge over that difference. On a similar note, Watson demonstrates that contemporary digital infrastructures now allow small-scale creators to reach

audiences and establish professional connections across geographical distances in ways previously unimaginable (Watson 2024, 668). Indeed, physical location has since then become less important than connectivity.

More than a practical arrangement, the bedroom studio embodies a broader spatial reconfiguration in which cultural production becomes detached from centralized locations. At the same time, digital platforms have centralized another type of space producers now depend on. If community belonging is produced through shared symbolic references rather than geographical proximity, they also constitute a set of shared spatial signifiers that create a given limit to the collective sense of place despite the absence of a common physical location.

From a Lefebvrian perspective, Barber Beats therefore represents more than a musical genre. It constitutes a socially produced digital space sustained through platform infrastructures, symbolic practices, and everyday interactions. Its members occupy different countries, languages, and social contexts, yet they participate in a common spatial order generated through digital technologies. Understanding this production of space is essential because it reveals that the community examined in this thesis is not simply located on YouTube. Rather, it is continuously produced through the interactions, representations, and practices that unfold across the digital environments in which its members live, create, and connect.

III.3. The Attention Economy and Authenticity

III.3.a. Citton and Zuboff: attention as the scarce resource

If platforms produce social space, as argued above, then the central question becomes what governs activity within that space. Due to digital environments not being constrained by the scarcity of physical resources in the traditional sense (music, videos, images and commentary can be reproduced and distributed at virtually no cost); what remains scarce is the capacity of users to engage with this abundance. In platformized cultural environments, attention becomes the primary resource around which visibility, participation and cultural value are organized.

This shift is strikingly evident on YouTube. The platform hosts an almost inexhaustible quantity of content, making it impossible for users to evaluate every available option. Rather than navigating this abundance independently, users increasingly rely on recommendation systems to filter and prioritize information for them. In this context, the platform's function extends beyond hosting content: it actively allocates attention. Recommendation algorithms determine which videos appear on home pages, in sidebars, and in autoplay sequences, thereby influencing which creators gain visibility and which remain largely unseen.

The operation of these systems relies on the continuous collection and processing of user behavior. Hracs and Webster observe that platforms increasingly understand users as 'dividuated' individuals, composed of multiple identities with different preferences, needs and behaviours performed at different moments in time (Hracs et al 2020, 247). That means that rather than addressing audiences as stable social groups, platforms construct dynamic behavioral profiles from countless interactions, using these profiles to predict and shape future engagement. Therefore, visibility is not simply tied to artistic quality or cultural significance, but to a platform's ability to anticipate and retain user attention.

This process is not neutral. Seaver characterizes recommender systems as 'captivating technologies,' arguing that their design cannot be separated from broader cultural assumptions and social practices. Recommendation algorithms do not merely respond to existing preferences; they participate in creating them. By repeatedly exposing users to certain forms of content while obscuring others, they influence the trajectories through which communities develop and cultural tastes emerge. The circulation of barber beats on YouTube is therefore not solely the result of listeners independently discovering a genre. It is also the consequence of a technical infrastructure designed to capture, maintain, and redirect attention.

From this perspective, the apparent democratization of cultural production introduced by digital platforms reveals an important paradox. While barriers to creation and distribution have dramatically decreased, competition for visibility has intensified. Every creator, regardless of their intentions, participates in a system where success depends upon attracting and retaining attention. Even communities that position themselves outside mainstream commercial structures remain embedded within these dynamics. Barber beats producers may reject conventional industry pathways, avoid extensive monetization, and cultivate anonymity, yet their work still circulates through infrastructures optimized around engagement metrics. Their music becomes part of an economy in which attention functions as the fundamental

currency. Moreover, the unique outsider position of the subgenre may play in its favor, for its 'authentic' aspect acting as a selling point.

III.3.b. Community-driven authenticity as resistance and gatekeeping

The dominance of attention-based platform logics does not mean that communities passively accept every consequence of algorithmic visibility. Alongside technical systems of recommendation, digital subcultures develop their own mechanisms for evaluating participation and regulating belonging. In the barber beats community, one of the most important of these mechanisms is authenticity.

The importance of authenticity can be traced to the genre's origins. Vaporwave and its related subgenres emerged from highly participatory online cultures in which listeners frequently became creators themselves. Guichardaz describe this dynamic through the figures of the “Do It Yourself” artist and the “prosumer”, (producer-consumer) emphasizing how independent music cultures are built upon the collapse of traditional distinctions between production and consumption (Guichardaz et al 2018, 668). Within such environments, legitimacy is rarely granted through institutional recognition alone. Instead, it is negotiated collectively through shared norms, aesthetic conventions, and community expectations.

Importantly, these forms of gatekeeping should not be understood as entirely separate from platform infrastructures. Analytical attention should be directed toward sociotechnical systems rather than algorithms in isolation, argues Seaver, since human actors remain integral components of algorithmic environments. The visibility of a creator is therefore shaped simultaneously by recommendation systems and by community reactions to that visibility. Algorithmic exposure may introduce new artists to listeners, but communities ultimately participate in determining whether those artists are accepted as authentic members of the cultural space.

This tension is particularly visible in communities such as barber beats, where rapid visibility can itself become a source of suspicion. Excessive popularity may be interpreted as evidence of commercial compromise, while artists perceived as reproducing the genre's aesthetic codes without participating in its underlying values can face criticism or exclusion. Authenticity thus functions both as a protective mechanism and as a form of social regulation.

It protects the community from complete assimilation into platform-driven logics of visibility, while simultaneously producing new boundaries that define who belongs and who does not.

The result is a dynamic relationship between algorithmic and human forms of curation. Platforms allocate attention according to engagement and behavioral prediction, whereas communities allocate legitimacy according to shared cultural norms. Neither system operates independently of the other. Instead, the cultural space of barber beats is produced through their continuous interaction. If platforms determine what can be seen and digital communities transform those infrastructures into lived social spaces, then authenticity emerges as one of the principal mechanisms through which participants negotiate the consequences of attention scarcity. It is through this process that communities attempt to preserve cultural coherence within environments fundamentally structured by competition for visibility.

IV. Methodology

In their 2018 article on the far right's use of YouTube as an informational battlefield, Kaiser and Rauchfleisch already identified the platform as an 'alternative media network, a hybrid counterculture of entertainers, journalists, and commentators' (Kaiser et al 2018). Pioneers of the YouTube API in social sciences studies, aside from the political consequences of bots and fake news they pointed to bring to light a number of fundamental concepts regarding the platform. They question why there were so little scholarly discussions on social media bigger than Twitter (YouTube reaches 2.7 billion monthly users in January 2025) and disproportionately popular with younger generations. Together with the New York Times article of Zeynep Tufekci, they also point at the early stages of the YouTube algorithm's dangerous nature: it leads viewers to increasingly extremist topics and skews information to the point of creating content eco-chambers (Tufekci 2018). Lastly and most importantly for this topic, Kaiser and Rauchfleisch recognized the central role of communities in this environment and how they are impacted by the platform: '[a]s our data shows, the channel recommendation connects diverse channels that might be more isolated without the influence of the algorithm' (Kaiser et al 2018). Complementarily, the insight of Bergsrom and Rosvall frame the importance of finding balance in the information conveyed when exposing the results of social network analysis research (Rosvall et al 2018, 1123). Hence, I will here aim for clarity: simultaneously shining light on the obscure part of the concepts discussed but also attempting to maintain all of them visible and attainable throughout.

IV.1. Research Design and Theoretical Grounding

This study adopts Social Network Analysis (SNA) as its primary methodological framework. Rather than treating community as an abstract concept, SNA makes it possible to operationalize social organization through measurable relationships between actors. Networks are composed of nodes and edges, representing entities and their interactions respectively, while metrics such as edge weight, clustering, and centrality provide empirical indicators of community structure. In the context of YouTube-based music subcultures, this approach allows the observation of patterns that remain largely invisible through conventional qualitative observation.

The objective of this research model is not simply to observe a musical genre, but to examine how a digital platform participates in shaping the conditions through which a cultural community becomes visible and organized. To do so, three complementary dimensions of interaction are examined: audience overlap through co-commenting networks, metadata practices through tag co-usage networks, and direct institutional relationships through channel recommendation and subscription networks.

I base the validity of my operationalization on the recommendations of the authors of a set of tools developed for network analysis. The YouTube Data Tools developer Bernhard Rieder (indirectly) guided me through the trial-and-error nature of data extraction and ForceAtlas2's critical understanding of social network analysis tools steered me in using Gephi for its interactive engineering (Jacomy et al 2014).

IV.2. Channel Selection and Sample Construction

The empirical sample consists of twelve YouTube channels. I selected ten YouTube Barber Beats channels that act as core representatives of the community based on audience size and visibility within the genre. Selection was not based solely on subscriber counts; channels were also chosen to represent different positions within the community, including variations in production style, distribution practices, and audience scale. To those, I added two outliers. First Denz1000, a music producer that also found success through YouTube but in a different genre, to determine whether audience overlap extended beyond genre boundaries. Secondly, whatsis?, a channel relying heavily on AI-generated vaporwave content. I decided to introduce this case as a methodological stress test, allowing observation of how a community founded on DIY production and artistic transformation responds to a producer that replicates genre aesthetics while challenging underlying assumptions regarding creativity and authorship.

The semi-anonymous nature of the barber beats scene required manual collection of channel identifiers. No comprehensive directory of artists exists, reflecting the genre's broader strategy of semi-visibility and decentralized organization. Additionally, out of the twenty Barber Beats producers I originally identified, only these ten had a meaningful and direct presence on YouTube, the others being scattered through other platforms such as Bandcamp, Soundcloud and Lastfm. Since data extraction is much harder on those platforms, and Youtube remains the one where a majority of interactions happen, I stuck with this sample.

IV.3. Data Extraction

IV.3.a. Channel Network Attempt

For the first stage of data collection, I focused on direct channel relationships. Using the channel network functionality of YouTube Data Tools, I extracted channel recommendation and subscription links for each of the twelve channels.

The results were unexpectedly sparse. Only two channels displayed any detectable connections to other channels in the sample. Although this initially appeared to be a methodological dead end, the absence of observable ties ultimately became a significant finding in itself. Unlike many online communities that publicly signal affiliation through subscriptions and recommendations, barber beats artists appear to maintain community cohesion through mechanisms that are largely invisible at the platform level.

IV.3.b. Video and Tag Data Collection

In the second stage, I tried extracting all videos associated with the selected channels alongside their metadata. By once again plugging the channel IDs in Youtube Data Tools interface, I obtained a joint list of all of their video IDs together with all the tags they have used in these, amounting to a total of 5668 videos and 300 000 tags. With this method, rather than extracting friendship relations or listening histories, the data scraped focused on audience interactions and metadata practices as indicators of community formation.

IV.3.c. Data Reduction and Filtering

The size of the initial dataset turned out to be way above the limit of what both R and Gephi could handle (22GB when their maximum is 5GB). I was forced to operate a rescaling of the data through a filtering strategy aimed at reducing noise while preserving analytically meaningful interactions. To get rid of weaker nodes, I exported it as a csv file and filtered through two criteria. First, I removed any video with less than 25 comments, as co-commenting

constitutes the primary basis for edge formation in subsequent analyses, so videos with minimal audience participation contribute little meaningful information to the network structure. Then, I filtered out any videos with a like count under 100, because two channels (VaporMemory and theuppermostinlife) have significantly more uploaded videos but with a lower engagement on average, so this reduces the impact of their less relevant content on the results. With these adjustments, I managed to reduce the number of videos to 1321.

IV.4. Co-commenting Network Construction

The co-commenting section of the Youtube Data Tools website looks at the top comments from the inputted videos whose users also commented on another video. I experimented with several sampling configurations: my initial trials using the top 1,000 comments per video introduced a substantial bias toward larger channels, whose videos more frequently accumulated comment volumes of that scale. To maintain comparability across channels, I therefore set the threshold to the minimum: 100 comments.

I cross-referenced the adjusted list of videos to get a GDF file containing edges representing links between videos weighted by how many users commented on both videos. I also aggregated these interactions at the channel level, producing a network in which nodes corresponded to channels instead of videos and edge weights represented audience overlap. This step was surprisingly handy as it also supplied me with a list of direct links between the channels: here the nodes are channels instead of videos, but the edges work in the same way as their value depends on co-commenting counts. Because of the smaller size of this file I managed to recalculate it using the full dataset of 5,668 videos, providing a more accurate representation of inter-channel relationships.

IV.5. Processing in R and Gephi

Then, inputting these files in R allowed me to directly look at the comments between artists, the proportion of similar tags they used, and the potential channel network. The goal of this file inspection in R was also to try combining the data frames to get a bigger picture when visualizing them in Gephi. The nature of the data (all igraph data frames) made it complicated

to do so however, and later on when trying to manipulate the combined data in Gephi I decided to let this idea aside as there was more than enough to work with in all individual files. Lastly, R allowed me to plot some simple graphs that pointed me in the right direction when making more sophisticated ones later on.

The final visualization and network interpretation were conducted in Gephi using the ForceAtlas2 layout algorithm. By treating edge relationships as attractive forces and node repulsion as a balancing mechanism, ForceAtlas2 reveals clusters and proximity structures that facilitate interpretation of community organization. The resulting visualizations form the basis of the empirical analysis presented in the following chapter.

V. Results: Network Structures and Community Patterns

V.1. The Co-commenting Network: Mapping Shared Audiences

V.1.a. Network Topology and Visual Interpretation

After plotting the data in Gephi, I finally achieved the visualization I was trying to get at from the start. The co-commenting network reveals a community that is simultaneously fragmented and interconnected. At first glance, on Figure 1 {note: all figures are in the appendix} the filtration process through which I hoped to better balance the number of videos per channel appears to have failed: the majoritarian red dots are videos from VaporMemory (see Figure 2 for details on colors).

However, upon closer inspection, the node quantity does not necessarily correspond to structural importance. Many of the largest nodes, representing highly liked videos, occupy peripheral positions within the network. This suggests that their popularity extends beyond the immediate barber beats community and may involve viewers arriving from adjacent musical or algorithmic pathways.

A second striking feature of Figure 1 is the emergence of clearly differentiated color clusters corresponding to individual artists. Channels such as Flamingosis display highly cohesive internal structures, with audience interactions occurring primarily within the boundaries of the artist's own catalogue as very few edges link them to the rest of the network. Another example of this phenomenon is the cross-genre outlier Denz1000, which forms an exceptionally dense but largely isolated cluster. The lack of substantial connections between Denz1000 and the barber beats core suggests that audience overlap remains strongly constrained by genre identity. His audience does not engage with others but seems very involved within his channel as the gravity of his videos is one of the densest ones on the graph.

On the polar opposite side when it comes to gravity, Snowpoint Lounge's videos can be found all around the network. Although represented by comparatively few videos, its nodes are dispersed throughout the network and connected by numerous inter-cluster edges. This does not mean Snowpoint Lounge's community disregards other videos of the same artist: Figure 3's

sharp color contrast puts forward edges connecting its video, and the thickness of these links indicates a high weight value of these edges, meaning co-comments are very common. Rather, the dispersion indicates a highly mobile audience that participates across multiple sectors of the community. Instead of a self-contained audience enclave, Snowpoint Lounge's versatile community seems to occupy a bridging position linking otherwise distinct listener groups.

At the channel level, a more coherent core begins to emerge. Macroblank, Mabisyo, and Slowerpace occupy particularly central positions, forming the backbone of the largest interconnected cluster. With context, it is easy to understand the three channel's closeness: they are the more established artists of this genre with consistent upload schedules and stable engagement. Figure 4 confirms their establishment: with rescaled weights, our attention is directed at inter-channel communities, and the three artists mentioned above are part of the biggest network. Although the overwhelming red dots dominate in Figures 1, 2 and 3, Figure 4 shows its limits: VaporMemory is a curator account that distributes music from various smaller vaporwave artists in a single channel. Its isolation seems to show that communities prefer engaging directly with the artists, and they themselves confirm this in Figure 4.

This figure also settles another debate of this thesis. The biggest cluster is located around Macroblank's channel, and stems across many others, cementing them as a centralizing actor. Coincidentally, Macroblank is one of the only two artists that directly engages with other channels by recommending and subscribing to them. As mentioned earlier, this form of support does not seem popular in this network, but since the other channel to do so is theuppermostinlife and it is also central in Figure 5, we can conclude that showing interest to other artists is beneficial to them in the end. Nevertheless, in the face of overwhelming absence of such connection across other barber beats artists, it appears that communities remain highly cohesive while leaving only minimal traces within the official social graphs provided by platforms.

The other notable feature of Figure 5 is the weak centrality of 'what is?'. This AI produced music channel, although uploading similar music to the other channels, received a very different treatment from the community. Mostly visible on Figure 1, the community formed by 'what is?' viewers is the furthest from the rest of the network and very few edges cross to any other channel and confirms the vaporwave community does not welcome this type of music production.

Lastly, Figure 6 shows what tags are most often used by the channels of this network. This tag network reveals a different dimension of community organization: unlike the co-

commenting network, which captures audience behavior, tags represent deliberate choices made by creators. A small group of terms dominates the network. 'Vaporwave,' 'Post-Vaporwave,' and 'Barber Beats' appear on substantially more videos than any other tags, forming a dense central cluster around which more specialized descriptors are organized. This concentration suggests a remarkable degree of consensus regarding how the genre should be categorized and discovered.

The predominance of these tags also highlights the continuing relationship between barber beats and its vaporwave origins. Although many artists and listeners distinguish the genres conceptually, metadata practices indicate that creators continue to rely on established vaporwave terminology as a means of maintaining discoverability.

More specialized tags occupy peripheral positions. Their relative rarity suggests that they function either as markers of niche stylistic variation or as attempts to connect videos to adjacent recommendation pathways.

Taken together, the three networks reveal complementary dimensions of the barber beats community. The co-commenting network identifies audience circulation. The tag network captures collective metadata practices. The channel network exposes the near absence of formal institutional ties. None of these dimensions alone provides a complete account of community formation, but together they reveal a coherent structure.

Several channels emerge as central across multiple dimensions, particularly Macroblank, Mabisyo, Slowerpace, and Snowpoint Lounge. Their importance stems not simply from audience size but from their capacity to connect otherwise distinct sectors of the network. Equally relevant are the two outlier cases. One confirms the persistence of genre boundaries (Denz1000) and limited audience overlap across stylistically different communities. The second, by contrast, is formally similar to other Barber Beats channels, but its AI generated content explains its poor community integration.

The results therefore point toward mechanisms of authenticity, gatekeeping, and identity construction that cannot be fully explained through structural analysis alone. These mechanisms form the focus of the following chapter.

VI. Analysis: Mechanisms of Platformization in the Barber Beats Community

VI.1. Fragmentation and the Rise of Micro-Audiences

One of the defining consequences of digital distribution has been the multiplication of cultural niches. Reducing the costs associated with production, storage, and distribution, digital infrastructures enabled increasingly specialized forms of cultural expression to survive outside traditional institutional structures. Mortimer argues that the expansion of digital circulation increases awareness of smaller and more obscure artists by making their work available through a growing number of channels (Mortimer et al 2010, 3). Rather than concentrating attention around a limited set of gatekeepers, digital systems create the conditions for a proliferation of niche cultural spaces.

The Barber Beats community observed in this study represents an advanced manifestation of this tendency. Although the channels examined in this study belong to the same micro-genre, the co-commenting network reveals that listeners do not engage with Barber Beats as a single undifferentiated audience. Instead, audience participation is organized around individual creators, producing multiple overlapping micro-publics.

This tendency is particularly visible in the case of Flamingosis. The channel's videos form a tightly bounded cluster whose edges overwhelmingly connect to other Flamingosis releases while maintaining only limited connections to the broader network. It seems even within a community already considered niche by mainstream standards, smaller communities emerge around specific artists. Similarly, Denz1000, the non-vaporwave outlier, possesses a highly engaged audience, and its near-isolation from the Barber Beats core demonstrates that audience overlap remains strongly constrained by cultural identity. Even within an environment theoretically characterized by limitless discoverability, digital abundance has not dissolved genre boundaries. On the contrary, the reduction of distribution barriers appears to have encouraged the formation of increasingly specialized audience formations competing for visibility within the same platform environment. Alexandre's observation confirms this claim when they stipulate that digitization simultaneously expands cultural supply and intensifies competition for attention (Alexandre et al 2022, 4). The result is not a universal marketplace

of culture, but a fragmented ecology composed of thousands of small and partially overlapping publics.

At the same time, the network demonstrates that fragmentation does not necessarily imply isolation. Despite the existence of artist-centered clusters, the co-commenting network also reveals a recognizable core. Macroblank, Mabisyo, and Slowerpace occupy positions through which multiple audience groups intersect, while Snowpoint Lounge functions as a bridge connecting otherwise distinct sectors of the network. Their importance does not stem solely from audience size. Rather, these channels facilitate circulation between micro-audiences that would otherwise remain more isolated.

This dual structure reveals an important characteristic of platformized cultural production. The algorithm simultaneously fragments and integrates. Recommendation systems encourage increasingly specialized consumption patterns by adapting to user histories and preferences, but they also create opportunities for movement between adjacent niches. If listeners may initially arrive through a single artist, repeated recommendation cycles expose them to neighboring creators, gradually generating the audience overlaps visible in the network. The result is much more complex than a mass audience or a collection of isolated silos; it's an interconnected landscape of micro-audiences.

The semi-visibility strategy historically cultivated by Barber Beats artists contributes to this structure. As discussed earlier, many producers deliberately avoid forms of exposure that could attract copyright enforcement, commercialization, or excessive mainstream attention. Such practices operate as a self-limiting growth mechanism. Remaining partially obscure restricts algorithmic amplification while preserving the intimacy and cultural coherence of the community, while the tags and graphic style attract attention. This balance of discoverability with autonomy makes the genre's structural feature a competitive advantage in face of Youtube's categoric algorithm.

VI.2. Algorithmic Curation as Cultural Gatekeeper

Throughout this thesis, the recurring phrase found in Barber Beats comment sections “the algorithm strikes again” has served as a point of entry into the relationship between platform infrastructures and community formation. The network analysis conducted here allows this popular intuition to be examined empirically. Although users often describe their

discovery of Barber Beats as accidental, the structure of the observed networks suggests that these encounters are neither random nor entirely user-directed. Rather, they emerge from a system of algorithmic curation that increasingly functions as a cultural gatekeeper, shaping not only what listeners hear but which communities they come to inhabit.

To understand this, it is first necessary to revisit the conditions under which Barber Beats circulates. As Maasø observes, one of the defining features of interactive streaming services is the access they provide to vast libraries whose contents can be retrieved on demand, anywhere and at any time (Maasø 2016, 154). Under such conditions, the primary challenge for any cultural producer is no longer access but selection: the quantity of available material vastly exceeds the capacity of any individual user to navigate independently. Recommendation systems therefore become unavoidable intermediaries between creators and audiences, performing the curatorial function that was once entrusted to radio programmers, record label scouts, and music critics. Christensen further notes that "By providing personalized and more varied music recommendations, streaming services can help listeners discover new songs and artists more frequently than through terrestrial radio" (Christensen 2022, 3). For a genre lacking traditional promotional infrastructures, this function is structurally indispensable.

The structure of the co-commenting network provides empirical evidence of this intermediary role. The central positions occupied by Macroblank, Mabisyo, and Slowerpace within the co-commenting graph suggest that listeners repeatedly move between these channels in patterns too consistent to be fully explained by deliberate individual exploration. Their overlap is not the product of direct institutional connections — the channel network found almost none — but of audience circulation shaped by recommendation pathways. Users encounter adjacent creators through autoplay sequences, sidebar suggestions, and algorithmically assembled playlists; they integrate these creators into their listening habits and subsequently generate the audience overlaps visible in the network. The structure that emerges is not one that any artist designed. It is one that the platform, responding to accumulated behavioral signals, has organized on their behalf.

Recommendation algorithms do not merely sort existing preferences into an efficient order; they participate actively in shaping the conditions under which preferences emerge. Visibility becomes unevenly distributed according to pathways generated by algorithmic systems, and those pathways help determine which creators become central nodes within a community and which remain at its periphery. To describe this as passive distribution would

be to misunderstand the constitutive role the algorithm plays in organizing cultural space. The recommendation engine does not find a pre-existing audience for a pre-existing genre; it assembles both simultaneously, through countless incremental acts of suggestion.

The tag network offers a complementary form of evidence. The remarkable standardization around labels such as 'vaporwave,' 'post-vaporwave,' and 'barber beats' is not the product of any coordinating authority; no label, institution, or manifesto has prescribed this vocabulary. Yet it has nonetheless converged across a decentralized community of producers, suggesting that creators have collectively learned to communicate in the platform's preferred language. Metadata functions here not merely as description but as a strategy for algorithmic legibility. By clustering around shared tags, creators increase the probability that their content will be indexed alongside similar work, that it will appear in the recommendation feeds of users already engaged with the genre, and that it will be correctly classified by systems that cannot listen to music but can read the textual context in which it is embedded. The community has, in effect, reverse-engineered a portion of the recommendation logic and incorporated it into its collective production practice.

Hracs and Webster argue that competition on digital platforms increasingly depends not on content alone but on the ability to engineer compelling experiences that mobilize the unique and interconnected affordances of platformization (Hracs et al 2020, 240). The Barber Beats case illustrates this acutely. Success in this environment requires not only compositional skill but a working knowledge of thumbnail design, tag vocabulary, title aesthetics, and release timing. These are not peripheral considerations; they are the means through which a piece of music enters the platform's recommendation logic and becomes eligible for discovery. Algorithmic curation thus operates as a form of gatekeeping that is structurally prior to human gatekeeping: it determines which content enters the circulation system at all, before any community member has the opportunity to evaluate it.

However, the findings also reveal the limits of algorithmic curation as a complete account of community organization. If recommendation systems were sufficient to explain the community's structure, one would expect some correspondence between the audience networks and the official social graph exposed through channel subscriptions and recommendations. Yet, as detailed in the results, that social graph was almost entirely absent. Only two channels displayed any detectable institutional connections at the platform level, despite the existence of substantial audience overlap across the full dataset. This discrepancy is significant. It reveals

that the algorithm successfully connects listeners to content, but does not necessarily connect creators to one another. Audience circulation emerges through recommendation infrastructures, while artist relationships remain largely invisible to platform-level social mechanisms.

The Barber Beats community therefore depends on algorithmic curation for discovery while simultaneously maintaining forms of cohesion that exceed what the platform itself is capable of representing. Shared metadata practices, aesthetic conventions, and community norms operate in registers the algorithm cannot access. The platform provides the infrastructure through which new listeners arrive; the community provides the symbolic order through which they are integrated or excluded. Algorithmic curation opens the door; community gatekeeping decides who enters. Neither system operates independently of the other, and it is their interaction, rather than either in isolation, that produces the community structure visible in the data.

VI.3. Authenticity, Gatekeeping, and the Treatment of 'Bad Fit' Actors

The most revealing result of this study may be the treatment of actors positioned at the margins of the community. The inclusion of Denz1000 and the AI-generated channel *whatis?* was intended as a methodological stress test. Together, these cases illuminate how authenticity functions as a mechanism of cultural governance.

The history of Barber Beats is deeply rooted in DIY production practices. As Guichardaz notes, independent music cultures have long been associated with figures such as the DIY artist and the prosumer, for whom participation in production constitutes a fundamental component of cultural identity (Guichardaz et al 2018, 844). Barber Beats emerged from precisely such conditions. Sampling, editing, transformation, and personal curation are not incidental elements of the genre; they constitute its creative ethos.

Against this background, the position of *whatis?* becomes particularly significant. From the perspective of platform metadata, the channel appears broadly compatible with the genre. It uses similar visual aesthetics, similar tags, and produces music that can easily be categorized alongside Barber Beats and vaporwave content. Yet its position within the co-commenting network differs dramatically from that of core community members. Audience overlap remains limited, and the channel occupies one of the most peripheral positions in the dataset.

This finding suggests that community membership cannot be reduced to algorithmic similarity. The recommendation system may classify content according to formal characteristics, but audiences evaluate it according to cultural meaning. The rejection of the AI channel therefore reveals the existence of authenticity criteria operating independently of platform logic. Listeners appear willing to treat stylistically similar content as culturally illegitimate when it violates the community's underlying assumptions regarding creativity, authorship, and artistic labor.

The Denz1000 case reveals a complementary dynamic. Here the problem is not authenticity but cultural distance. Unlike the AI channel, Denz1000 is recognized as a legitimate creator. Nevertheless, audience overlap with the Barber Beats core remains weak. The result suggests that genre boundaries continue to structure participation even in environments characterized by algorithmic recommendation and limitless accessibility. Discovery may occur across genres, but belonging remains selective.

Taken together, these cases reveal that community gatekeeping operates as a corrective mechanism layered on top of algorithmic curation. Platforms are largely indifferent to cultural fit. Recommendation systems connect content according to patterns of engagement and similarity, not according to shared values or collective identities. Communities, by contrast, evaluate participation according to criteria that remain largely invisible to algorithmic systems.

This observation recalls Seaver's argument that the distinction between humans and algorithms should not be treated as absolute, since both are produced through their interaction with one another (Seaver 2015, 7). The Barber Beats community does not simply resist platform logic, nor does it merely submit to it. Rather, community members continuously reinterpret and regulate the outcomes generated by algorithmic systems. Authenticity policing functions as a form of human curation that compensates for the platform's inability to distinguish cultural legitimacy from formal similarity.

VI.4. Metadata, Titles, and Thumbnails as Identity Signals

The final mechanism revealed by this study operates at the level of representation. If audience networks capture behavior and channel networks capture institutional relationships, metadata captures how a community chooses to present itself both to audiences and to algorithms.

The tag network demonstrates a remarkable degree of standardization. Despite the decentralized nature of the community, a small set of labels dominates metadata practices across channels. This consistency suggests the existence of informal norms regarding how Barber Beats should be categorized and discovered. In this sense, metadata functions as a form of collective governance. The organization and presentation of information is no longer secondary to cultural production; it is part of cultural production itself.

The significance of metadata extends beyond tags. Throughout the community, creators employ a recognizable visual grammar composed of retro imagery, nostalgic urban landscapes, consumer-era iconography, and deliberately enigmatic titles. These elements perform a dual function. They signal genre membership to human audiences while simultaneously increasing the probability that content will be correctly interpreted by platform infrastructures. A thumbnail or title therefore operates as both a cultural marker and a visibility strategy.

The tag network further suggests that not all metadata serves the same purpose. Some tags appear to function as identity markers, signalling membership within the Barber Beats tradition. Others operate primarily as navigational tools designed to maximize discoverability. The continued prominence of terms such as 'vaporwave' alongside 'barber beats' illustrates this distinction. Although many participants regard the genres as distinct, creators continue to rely on established vaporwave terminology because it remains useful within the platform's discovery infrastructure.

From this perspective, metadata emerges as the most consciously managed layer of community organization. Comment networks reflect audience behavior and channel networks reveal limited institutional relationships, but metadata represents deliberate strategic action. It is the dimension over which creators possess the greatest degree of control. As Vizcaíno-Verdú argues, platformization reshapes the production, distribution, and circulation of cultural content (Vizcaíno-Verdú et al 2023, 152). The Barber Beats community demonstrates this process clearly: creators do not simply produce music; they produce visibility.

Taken together, the four mechanisms identified in this chapter — micro-audience formation, algorithmic curation, authenticity gatekeeping, and metadata governance — provide an explanation for how a decentralized and semi-anonymous community can nevertheless achieve coherence. The Barber Beats network is not held together by formal institutional structures. Instead, it emerges from the interaction between platform affordances and community practices. The platform provides the infrastructure through which discovery

becomes possible, while community members continuously regulate meaning, identity, and belonging within that infrastructure. This interaction constitutes the central mechanism of platformization observed throughout the study.

VI.5. The Covid Interlude as Confirmation: Crisis, Normality, and the Genre's Structural Resilience

The preceding analyses have examined the Barber Beats community through the lens of its normal operating conditions: the mechanisms through which it fragments and coheres, the algorithmic pathways through which it is discovered, the authenticity norms through which it regulates belonging, and the metadata practices through which it manages its own visibility. Each of these mechanisms was already in place before 2020. The Covid-19 pandemic did not create them. What it did instead was subject them to an unprecedented stress test, briefly amplifying the community to a scale it had not previously reached and then receding, leaving the question of what, if anything, had changed. This section argues that the answer is: very little, and that this stability is itself the most theoretically significant finding of the study.

The supervisory frame guiding this thesis “media after the crisis: return to normality” acquires a specific and perhaps unexpected meaning in this context. For Barber Beats, the crisis was not a disruption of normality but a temporary suspension of its most defining feature: semi-visibility. The pandemic created the conditions for an anomalous surge in the genre's reach, introducing it to audiences far beyond those it would ordinarily have attracted. The normality to which the community has since returned is not a pre-digital condition of scarcity and physical cultural participation. It is the carefully managed, platform-dependent, algorithmically mediated semi-obscurity that Barber Beats had been constructing for a decade before the pandemic began. The crisis, in short, was the exception. Semi-visibility was always the norm.

Understanding why this is the case requires returning to the structural conditions of the pandemic itself. “COVID-19 condensed a decade of digital transformation into 18 months”, observes Einav (Einav 2022, 24). This dramatically accelerating patterns of media use and technology adoption that had been building gradually since the early 2000s. Alexandre describes this acceleration in cultural terms: the crisis hastened a paradigm shift in which the cultural sector moved from a logic of scarcity to one of abundance, with lockdowns fueling the substitution of predominantly physical consumption by remote and digitalized alternatives. The

consequence was a vast expansion of the online audience for digitally native cultural forms, including music genres that had previously circulated only within narrow platform-dependent communities.

Barber Beats was, structurally, already adapted for precisely this environment. While the general population was forced during lockdown into the kind of domestic, digitally mediated existence that Barber Beats artists had long normalized, the genre's audience expanded rapidly without requiring any change in the community's underlying infrastructure. Jonchery and Lombardo document this dynamic from the French case: the reorganization of time in domestic space during lockdown actively favored access to digital cultural goods, and the 15-to-24 age cohort that constitutes the core of Barber Beats' listenership developed amateur creative practices most intensively during this period. The genre did not need to adapt to pandemic conditions; it was those conditions, scaled up and pushed to an unprecedented audience.

The connection between pandemic aesthetics and the genre's core sensibility reinforced this dynamic. Barber Beats' defining qualities — temporal nostalgia, the evocation of liminal spaces, the slowed and distorted textures of a decelerated world, the introspective quality of music produced in solitude and consumed through headphones — resonated acutely with the psychological texture of lockdown. Listeners encountered, in the genre's imagery of empty shopping malls and deserted airport lounges, an aesthetic language for the uncanny suspension of ordinary life that the pandemic imposed. The comment sections from this period are full of precisely this recognition: listeners describing how they stumbled across the music 'at exactly the right moment,' how it named something they could not otherwise articulate. The algorithm was delivering them to a pre-existing community that felt as though it had been waiting.

Yet the community's gatekeeping mechanisms continued to operate throughout this period. The expansion of the audience did not translate into a corresponding relaxation of authenticity norms. The marginal position of the AI-generated channel *whatis?* in the co-commenting data — which was collected after the pandemic surge, during the normalization period — suggests that the community's evaluative criteria survived the influx of new listeners essentially intact. This is consistent with Seaver's argument that algorithmic systems and human cultural practices are not simply parallel but constitutively intertwined: the community's authenticity norms did not disappear when the algorithm delivered a larger audience; they were

reproduced through the interactions of that larger audience. New listeners, it appears, were socialized into the community's existing evaluative framework rather than diluting it.

Watson's findings about the post-pandemic digital transition in regional music production clusters provide useful context here. His research identifies the combination of digital distribution, social media promotion, and live streaming as enabling small-scale creators to reach across geographical space for audiences in ways previously unimaginable, and notes that revenue generated by independent artists represented the fastest-growing segment of the music business even before Covid accelerated these trends. For Barber Beats, this trajectory was already advanced before 2020; the pandemic compressed what might have been a gradual decade-long expansion into a much shorter period, but the structural conditions that made it possible — decentralized production, platform-mediated distribution, community-driven discovery — were already firmly in place.

The aftermath is equally instructive. As pandemic restrictions lifted and the general population's relationship to digital media partially normalized, the atypical audience that had discovered Barber Beats during lockdown dispersed. Some remained; the majority moved on. The community that emerged from this period was not dramatically different from the one that had entered it. The central channels identified in the co-commenting analysis — Macroblank, Mabisyo, Slowerpace, Snowpoint Lounge — retained their structural positions. The tag vocabulary remained standardized around the same cluster of genre identifiers. The channel subscription network remained nearly absent. In Lefebvrian terms, the socially produced digital space of Barber Beats had absorbed a temporary expansion and reconstituted its prior spatial logic without requiring any fundamental reorganization.

This resilience is not incidental. It reflects the fact that the community's semi-visibility is not a deficiency but a strategy, and that the strategy is structurally well-suited to the platform environment in which the genre operates. Jeannotte, writing on cultural value during the pandemic, observes that the crisis revealed how digital interconnectedness could sustain social relations and cultural participation in conditions of physical isolation. What the Barber Beats case adds to this observation is a specificity that broader cultural analyses tend to miss: not all communities benefited equally from digital interconnectedness, and those that were already organized around platform-native practices of production, distribution, and community formation were structurally better positioned than those attempting a rapid transition from physical to digital modes of engagement. Barber Beats did not pivot to digital; it had always

been digital. The crisis confirmed what its most committed members had long understood: that the bedroom, the DAW, and the recommendation algorithm were sufficient conditions for a functioning cultural community. The normality that returned after the crisis was, in the most precise sense, the genre's natural state.

VII. Discussion

The preceding chapters have moved from the historical formation of a musical subculture, through its theoretical conditions of existence, to an empirical account of the network structures that sustain it. What the analysis of the Barber Beats community on YouTube reveals is not simply the shape of one micro-genre's social graph. It reveals, more broadly, how cultural communities are formed, maintained, and made coherent within environments fundamentally structured by platform logics, and what it means for a community to persist within those environments while simultaneously refusing some of their central incentives. This discussion draws together the implications of those findings across three registers: what they suggest about platformized cultural production in general, what they reveal about the relationship between platform power and cultural autonomy, and where the limits of the study's claims lie.

VII.1. What Subcultures Teach Us About Platformized Cultural Production After the Crisis

One of the most persistent challenges in the study of digital culture is the difficulty of distinguishing genuinely new phenomena from older dynamics in new containers. Digital platforms are frequently described as transformative, disruptive, or revolutionary, yet many of the mechanisms they activate — competition for visibility, the formation of in-group identity, the negotiation between commercial and non-commercial values — are recognizable from the sociology of cultural production long predating the internet. The value of studying a micro-genre such as Barber Beats is precisely that it operates at a scale where these mechanisms remain legible. The community is small enough that structural patterns can be directly observed, yet sufficiently representative of platform-native cultural formation to support broader claims about how platformization shapes cultural life.

The central structural finding is evidently a community that is tightly integrated at the informal level and nearly invisible at the formal platform level. This implications that extend well beyond this particular genre. It suggests that platforms systematically misrepresent the communities they host. The metrics and social graphs that YouTube makes available to researchers, advertisers, and the public capture only the most institutionalized dimensions of

community life: subscription relationships, public recommendation links, aggregated engagement counts. They do not capture the shared aesthetic norms, the informal tag vocabularies, the community-enforced authenticity criteria, or the subtle circulation patterns that actually hold a community together. Any analysis that relies exclusively on platform-visible data will therefore underestimate community coherence, misattribute the causes of community organization, and fail to identify the mechanisms most responsible for a community's continuity.

This limitation is not merely methodological; it has a political dimension. Platforms benefit commercially from the communities they host while providing those communities with limited visibility into, and no meaningful control over, the infrastructures on which they depend. The near-absence of the channel subscription network is not evidence that Barber Beats artists lack relationships with one another; it is evidence that those relationships are maintained through channels the platform does not make legible. When platform-visible data becomes the primary basis for decisions about content moderation, recommendation weighting, or API access, communities whose social structures are mostly informal become structurally vulnerable to misclassification and neglect.

The pandemic provides the most pointed illustration of this dynamic. The supervisory premise framing this thesis — media after the crisis, return to normality — finds its clearest expression not in the recovery of pre-digital cultural institutions but in the reconstitution, after a period of anomalous expansion, of the platform-native community structures that had been quietly forming for a decade before the crisis arrived. Einav describes how Covid-19 condensed a decade of digital transformation into eighteen months, and how the niche media habits of digitally native generations migrated rapidly to older demographics (Einav 2022, 24). What the Barber Beats case adds to this observation is the longer arc: those niche habits did not emerge during the pandemic, and they did not disappear afterward. They were normalized by the crisis and then, when the crisis passed, retained by those for whom they had become genuinely meaningful. The return to normality in this context is not a return to a pre-platform condition. It is the consolidation of a platform-native condition as the new baseline.

This has consequences for how cultural policy and platform governance are understood. If the primary forms of cultural community formation are now taking place through informal mechanisms that platform-visible data does not capture, then policy frameworks designed around platform-legible metrics will consistently fail to account for the communities most

dependent on platform infrastructures. The genre that survives without label deals, radio play, or official platform promotion is precisely the genre most exposed to the decisions of a platform that does not know it exists in any institutionally legible form. Understanding how such communities maintain coherence — through metadata norms, authenticity policing, and audience circulation — is therefore not merely an academic exercise. It is a precondition for any serious engagement with the governance of cultural production in a platformized environment.

VII.2. Implications for Cultural Autonomy and Platform Power

The question of cultural autonomy in platformized environments is complicated by a structural irony that the Barber Beats case makes unusually visible. The genre emerged from an aesthetic and ethical disposition strongly opposed to the commercial logics of the mainstream music industry. Yet the community that enacted these refusals became, over the course of a decade, structurally dependent on one of the largest and most commercially driven platforms in the world. The autonomy that was asserted in relation to the record industry was, in effect, traded for a different form of dependence: a contractual obligation to algorithmic exposure and its terms of service.

There is logic to this tradeoff. Guichardaz observes that digital technologies have enabled supply and demand to meet without the institutional limitations of record label policies, and that independent music has become the fastest-growing segment of the business precisely because digital distribution removes barriers that once required institutional mediation (Guichardaz et al 2018, 884). For Barber Beats, this is structurally accurate: the genre could not have existed in its current form without the accessibility of digital distribution platforms, and it does not require label infrastructure to reach an audience. But the absence of one intermediary has not produced disintermediation in any full sense. It has produced re-intermediation through a different set of actors — recommendation algorithms, content identification systems, API access policies, and platform terms of service — whose decisions affect the community just as profoundly as any label contract, but without the contractual reciprocity that label relationships, however exploitative, at least formally involve.

Nguyen describe streaming as potentially the missing link between the music industry and the digital revolution, suggesting that these platforms offer a sustainable bridge between

the interests of creators and the demands of digital distribution (Nguyen et al 2014, 328). The Barber Beats case complicates this optimism. The platform provides the infrastructure for community formation and audience discovery, but the terms on which it does so are not negotiated. They are imposed. Content identification systems threaten to remove music that samples without clearance. API access restrictions constrain the tools available for community self-analysis. Recommendation logic is proprietary and opaque. Recording companies, Nguyen notes, retain greater influence over which artists are showcased on streaming services than the platforms' apparent openness suggests (id, 326). For independent artists operating at the margins of legality, the platform is not a neutral bridge but a precarious landlord whose priorities do not align with those of the community it incidentally hosts.

The datafication of subcultural behavior sharpens this asymmetry further. Every comment posted in a Barber Beats video thread, every tag added to a release, every watch-through that causes the algorithm to recommend the video again — each of these interactions generates behavioral data that the platform processes and monetizes. Community members participate in the production of this data without receiving any compensation, any transparency about how it is used, or any institutional protection in return. The community that understands itself as operating outside mainstream commercial logics is, at the level of platform data, no different from any other audience segment: a collection of behavioral signals to be optimized around.

The semi-visibility strategy, examined throughout this thesis as a mechanism of community self-regulation, can also be read in this light as a rational adaptation to platform power. In the absence of institutional protection from copyright enforcement, cultivated obscurity functions as the only available substitute for legal security. The deliberate maintenance of a low commercial profile, meaning no streaming revenue collected or real names used or press appearances made, is not simply an aesthetic preference for anonymity. It is a practical response to the structural vulnerability of a community whose core creative practice involves the unlicensed use of copyrighted material on a platform whose content identification systems are designed to detect and remove exactly that. In sum, the community manages its exposure to platform power by limiting the surface area through which platform power can reach it.

Nevertheless, if the community's independence from mainstream institutions is partly a function of its smallness, and if that smallness is partly maintained as a defensive strategy

against the platform on which it depends, then the autonomy in question is less a positive freedom than a negotiated condition of minimal exposure. It is not the autonomy of an actor who has escaped institutional constraint but of one who has found the optimal position within a constrained field. And that feat isn't nothing: it is a genuine and creative form of cultural agency, though it should not be mistaken for independence.

The inclusion of an AI-generated channel as a methodological outlier adds a further dimension to these questions that points beyond the immediate scope of this thesis. The community's response to *whatis?* demonstrates that authenticity criteria function as a corrective to algorithmic indifference. The platform classifies content according to formal similarity; the community evaluates it according to cultural meaning. Here the community appears to have reached a collective judgment that formal similarity is insufficient. They deemed that the genre's identity is bound up with a set of practices, commitments, and forms of labor that AI generation does not replicate. What makes this outcome all the more interesting is that this judgment was enacted not through any coordinated decision or explicit statement of policy but through the aggregate behavior of listeners whose comment patterns revealed a community choosing, without being asked, not to integrate this actor into its social fabric.

VII.3. Limitations of the Study

Any account of what this study demonstrates must be accompanied by a clear account of what it cannot demonstrate. Several limitations are structurally inherent to the methods and data sources available while others are more contingent, arising from specific decisions made in the research design whose effects on the findings should be acknowledged.

First, the most fundamental structural limitation is the opacity of the YouTube recommendation algorithm. The network structures observed in this study: audience overlaps, central positions of certain channels, marginal position of the AI-generated outlier; are consequences of recommendation logic operating across years of accumulated user behavior. They reflect the algorithm's outputs but not its inputs. The exact weighting of watch time, click-through rate, comment activity, and metadata compatibility in determining which videos are recommended alongside which others is proprietary and unavailable for inspection. This means that the study can describe the community structure that has emerged from algorithmic

processes without being able to specify the mechanisms within those processes that produced it.

A related limitation concerns the scope of the platform data available through the YouTube Data API. The API does not expose full subscription counts, complete recommendation graphs, private engagement signals, or the behavioral histories of individual users. The co-commenting network, which forms the empirical core of the analysis, captures only a proxy measure of community interaction: the overlap between the sets of users who commented on different videos. It does not capture lurkers, passive viewers, or the large proportion of community engagement that takes place in private channels such as Discord servers and direct messages. The community observed in this study is therefore, in a precise sense, the community that has chosen to make itself visible through public comment behavior, and this sample is systematically different from the community as a whole.

The data filtering decisions made during the research process introduce a further source of uncertainty. The thresholds applied — removing videos with fewer than 25 comments and fewer than 100 likes — were chosen to reduce noise and correct for channel-specific biases in upload volume and average engagement. The internal validity of the study is further fragilized: the study does not report sensitivity analyses across alternative threshold values, and the degree to which the findings are robust to variations in these parameters is therefore not established. This should be understood as a limitation of the present study rather than a fundamental challenge to its conclusions, though it is a limitation that future replications should address.

The semi-anonymity of Barber Beats artists poses a methodological challenge that proved impossible to fully resolve. The analysis treats channels as unitary actors, but the reality of community membership is more complex: some channels are managed by single individuals, others by small collectives, and the boundaries between artist, curator, and label are often unclear. The inability to confirm real identities, conduct interviews, or trace activity across platforms means that the analysis cannot access the motivations, relationships, and decision-making processes that underlie the network structures it observes. The structural patterns identified are real, but the human stories that produced them remain largely opaque. Qualitative methods artist interviews, participant observation in community spaces, ethnographic engagement with Discord servers and Bandcamp pages would be necessary to complement the structural account offered here and to interpret the motivations behind the behaviors the network data captures.

Finally, the study represents a temporal snapshot of a community that is dynamic. The data reflects a particular moment in the genre's history, during or shortly after the pandemic period that forms an important part of the interpretive framework. The pandemic itself is a confounding variable of unusual magnitude: it simultaneously expanded the genre's audience, reorganized the conditions of cultural consumption, and altered the behavioral patterns from which the co-commenting network is derived. The extent to which the network structures identified here reflect the genre's stable long-term organization, as opposed to patterns that emerged from or were distorted by the pandemic period, cannot be determined from the data alone.

VIII. Conclusion

This thesis set out to examine a recurring observation within the Barber Beats community on YouTube: “the algorithm strikes again.” Rather than treating Barber Beats as a simple aggregation of listeners sharing musical tastes, it approached the genre as a digital-native cultural formation whose structure could reveal how platforms, creators, and audiences collectively produce community.

Using historical contextualization, platform theory, and Social Network Analysis, a dataset of 5,668 videos and approximately 300,000 tags from twelve YouTube channels was used to reconstruct three complementary network layers: audience circulation through co-commenting, metadata practices through tag co-usage, and institutional relationships through channel subscriptions and recommendations. Together, these networks reveal a community that is highly coherent despite being largely invisible through YouTube’s formal social structures.

The findings support the central argument of this study. Barber Beats is not an accidental consequence of shared taste but a structured product of platform affordances, collective discoverability practices, and community-enforced authenticity norms. Its defining characteristic is the coexistence of strong informal integration and weak formal visibility. Community cohesion emerges through participation, circulation, and shared cultural codes rather than through public institutional ties.

The co-commenting network revealed an interconnected constellation of micro-audiences linked by central actors such as Macroblank, Mabisyo, Slowerpace, and Snowpoint Lounge. The tag network demonstrated a highly standardized metadata infrastructure that facilitates discoverability and adaptation to platform logics. Meanwhile, the near absence of subscription and recommendation links showed that community cohesion operates largely outside YouTube’s official social graph.

The four research questions can therefore be answered clearly. First, Barber Beats takes the form of a decentralized but highly integrated cultural network organized around audience circulation rather than formal creator relationships. Second, YouTube’s recommendation systems and metadata infrastructures function as powerful gatekeepers that shape pathways of discovery and visibility. Third, authenticity norms operate as a secondary layer of curation: while algorithms classify content through formal similarity, community members evaluate

cultural legitimacy, as illustrated by the marginal position of the AI-generated channel *whatis?*. Fourth, the case demonstrates that platformized cultural production emerges through continuous negotiation between platform infrastructures and community practices. Platforms create opportunities for encounter; communities create meaning and belonging.

The study's three hypotheses are strongly supported. Algorithmic recommendation significantly shapes the community's structure; shared metadata practices constitute a collective adaptation to platform infrastructures; and authenticity criteria operate independently from algorithmic classification. Together, these findings validate the broader claim that the algorithm creates the conditions of encounter, while the community creates the conditions of belonging.

The Covid-19 pandemic provides an important historical lens for interpreting these results. Rather than creating the mechanisms that sustain Barber Beats, the crisis temporarily generalized conditions that had long defined the genre: platform-dependent discovery, remote creativity, digitally mediated sociality, and geographically dispersed participation. The pandemic was therefore not the origin of the community's growth but a moment in which broader society briefly converged with its existing mode of operation. In this sense, Barber Beats' greatest visibility was the exception, while its return to semi-obscurity represents its normal state.

This thesis makes three contributions. Empirically, it provides one of the first Social Network Analyses of the Barber Beats community. Methodologically, it demonstrates the value of combining YouTube Data Tools, R, and Gephi within a multi-layer network framework applicable to other platform-based cultural communities. Theoretically, it contributes to debates on platformization by showing that cultural autonomy can persist within highly platform-dependent environments through collective practices of adaptation, regulation, and meaning-making.

Ultimately, Barber Beats illustrates a broader lesson about contemporary cultural production. Digital communities emerge neither solely because platforms connect people nor solely because individuals share interests. They emerge through the interaction of technological infrastructures and human practices. Platforms provide visibility; communities provide meaning. The enduring coherence of Barber Beats demonstrates that even in environments shaped by algorithms, cultural belonging remains a fundamentally social achievement.

Bibliography / Citation Index

- Alexandre, O., Algan, Y., & Benhamou, F. (2022). The digital age and crisis: The challenges facing culture. *Les Notes du Conseil d'Analyse Économique*, 70, 1–12.
<https://doi.org/10.3917/ncae.070.0001>
- Angelucci, C., Cagé, J., & Sinkinson, M. (2021). *Media competition and news diets* (NBER Working Paper No. 26782). National Bureau of Economic Research.
- Bergstrom, C. T., & Rosvall, M. (n.d.). Social network analysis and the communication of network results.
- Christensen, F. (2022). Streaming stimulates the live concert industry: Evidence from YouTube. *International Journal of Industrial Organization*, 85, 102873.
- Danielsen, A., & Kjus, Y. (2019). The mediated festival: Live music as trigger of streaming and social media engagement. *Convergence: The International Journal of Research into New Media Technologies*, 25(4), 714–734. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1354856517721808>
- Einav, G. (Ed.). (2022). *Transitioning media in a post-COVID world: Digital transformation, immersive technologies, and consumer behavior*. Springer Nature Switzerland.
- Guichardaz, R., Bach, L., & Penin, J. (2019). Music industry intermediation in the digital era and the resilience of the majors' oligopoly: The role of transactional capability. *Industry and Innovation*, 26(7), 843–869.
- Helmond, A. (2015). The platformization of the web: Making web data platform ready. *Social Media + Society*, 1(2). <https://doi.org/10.1177/2056305115603080>
- Hogue, E. (2024). The complementary relationship between live performances and post-concert streaming. *Applied Economics*, 56(58), 8437–8446.
- Hracs, B. J., & Webster, J. (2021). From selling songs to engineering experiences: Exploring the competitive strategies of music streaming platforms. *Journal of Cultural Economy*, 14(2), 240–257.
- Jacomy, M., Venturini, T., Heymann, S., & Bastian, M. (2014). ForceAtlas2, a continuous graph layout algorithm for handy network visualization designed for the Gephi software. *PLOS ONE*, 9(6), e98679. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0098679>

- Jeannotte, M. S. (2021). When the gigs are gone: Valuing arts, culture and media in the COVID-19 pandemic. *Social Sciences & Humanities Open*, 3(1), 100097.
- Jonchery, A., & Lombardo, P. (2020). *Pratiques culturelles en temps de confinement* (Culture Études 2020/6). Ministère de la Culture – DEPS.
- Kaiser, J., & Rauchfleisch, A. (2018). Unite the right? How YouTube's recommendation algorithm connects the U.S. far-right. *Medium*.
<https://medium.com/@MediaManipulation/unite-the-right-how-youtubes-recommendation-algorithm-connects-the-u-s-far-right-9f1387ccfabd>
- Lefebvre, H. (1991). *The production of space* (D. Nicholson-Smith, Trans.). Blackwell. (Original work published 1974)
- Maasø, A. (2018). Music streaming, festivals, and the eventization of music. *Popular Music and Society*, 41(2), 154–175.
- Montoro-Pons, J. D., Caballer-Tarazona, M., & Cuadrado-García, M. (2023). Assessing complementarities between live performances and YouTube video streaming. *Empirical Economics*, 66.
- Mortimer, J. H., Nosko, C., & Sorensen, A. (2010). *Supply responses to digital distribution: Recorded music and live performances* (NBER Working Paper No. 16507). National Bureau of Economic Research.
- My Pet Flamingo. (2026, April 22). *Nobody here | The story of vaporwave* [Film]. YouTube.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6kNqw7UdENg>
- Nguyen, G. D., Dejean, S., & Moreau, F. (2014). On the complementarity between online and offline music consumption: The case of free streaming. *Journal of Cultural Economics*, 38, 315–330.
- Rieder, B. (n.d.). *YouTube Data Tools* [Software]. University of Amsterdam.
- Rolling Stone. (2015, November 30). *10 new artists you need to know: November 2015*.
<https://www.rollingstone.com/music/music-lists/10-new-artists-you-need-to-know-november-2015-147133/2814-2-146036/>
- Rosvall, M., & Bergstrom, C. T. (2008). Maps of random walks on complex networks reveal community structure. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 105(4), 1118–1123. <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.0706851105>

- Seaver, N. P. (2015). *Computing taste: The making of algorithmic music recommendation* (Doctoral dissertation, University of California, Irvine).
- Ternovski, J., & Yasseri, T. (2020). Social complex contagion in music listenership: A natural experiment. *Social Networks*, 61, 144–152.
- Tufekci, Z. (2018, March 10). YouTube, the great radicalizer. *The New York Times*.
<https://www.nytimes.com/2018/03/10/opinion/sunday/youtube-politics-radical.html>
- Vizcaíno-Verdú, A., de-Casas-Moreno, P., & Tirocchi, S. (2023). Online prosumer convergence: Listening, creating and sharing music on YouTube and TikTok. *Communication & Society*, 36(1), 151–166. <https://doi.org/10.15581/003.36.1.151-166>
- Watson, A. (2024). Supporting regional music production clusters in the post-pandemic era: Placing business support at the heart of local cultural policy. *International Journal of Cultural Policy*, 30(5), 667–681.
- Zhang, Q., & Negus, K. (2021). Stages, platforms, streams: The economies and industries of live music after digitalization. *Popular Music and Society*, 44(5), 539–557.

Appendix

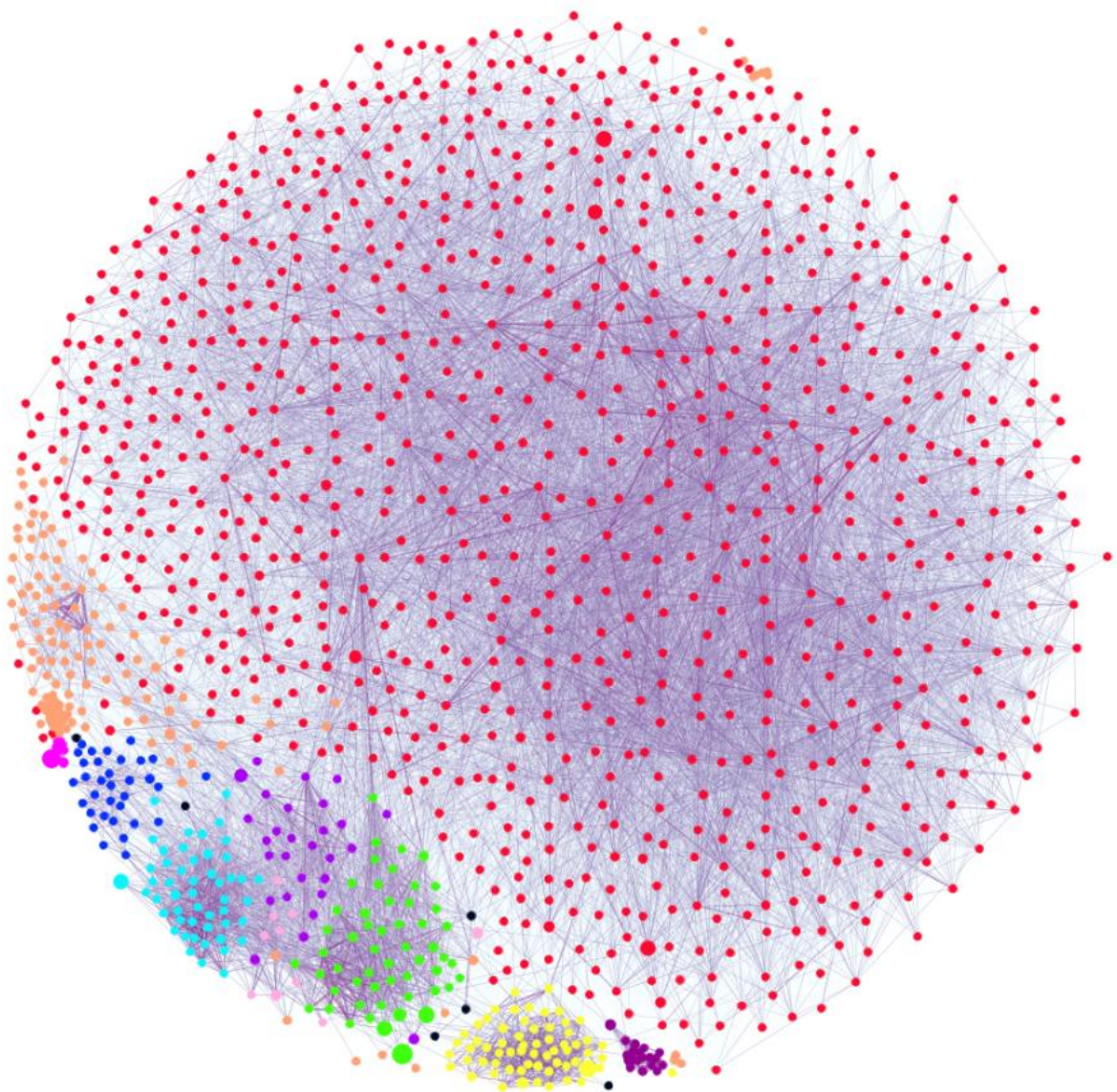


Figure1: Network of co-commented videos

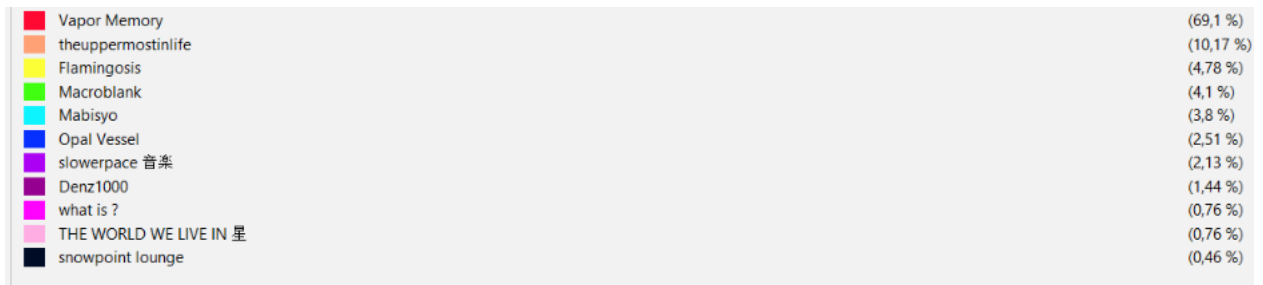


Figure 2: Supporting information for Fig1, with proportion of total nodes

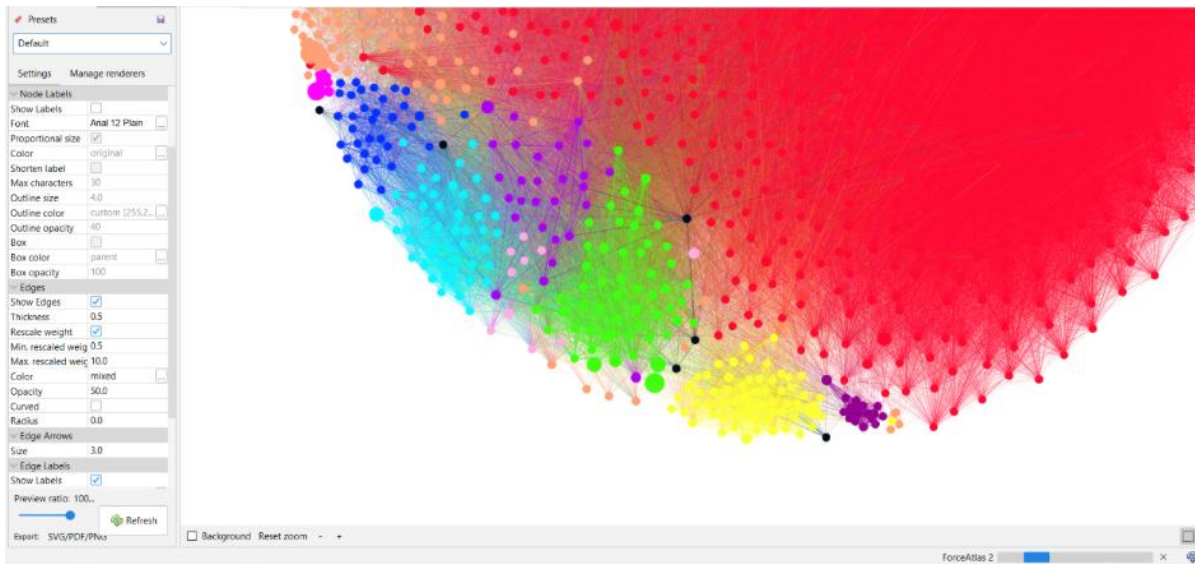


Figure 3: another look at Figure 1 but with edges colored according to the nodes they are connected to

